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**INDIA IS READY
TO HELP END
UKRAINE WAR:
EAM IN KYIV**

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: India stands ready to help in all efforts to end the war in Ukraine, external affairs minister S Jaishankar told the top Ukrainian leadership in Kyiv on Thursday, days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Russian President Vladimir Putin to move from "endless war to the end of war".

Peace efforts and the development of bilateral ties, including trade and investment, figured in discussions between the Ukrainian leadership and Jaishankar, the first external affairs minister to make a stand-alone visit to Kyiv. Jaishankar said on social media that approaches to end the conflict and deepen bilateral cooperation also figured in his meeting with President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. **→P5**

Belgium, India boost ties; pacts on defence manufacturing inked

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Belgian counterpart Bart De Wever on Thursday agreed to bolster cooperation in defence, advanced technology and law enforcement and set a target for doubling trade in five years, as defence firms of the two countries concluded co-production agreements for a wide range of military equipment.

Modi and De Wever, the first Belgian PM to visit India in two decades, reviewed bilateral ties and held focused discussions on collaboration in semiconductors, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, fintech, advanced manufacturing, ports and logistics, and clean energy.

The creation of resilient supply chains to reduce dependency on China and more predictable trade arrangements, including leveraging the proposed India-European Union (EU) free trade



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Belgian counterpart Bart De Wever in New Delhi on Thursday.

agreement, against the backdrop of geo-economic turmoil unleashed by US trade policies and tariffs also figured in the discussions between the two leaders.

Modi noted at a joint media interaction that food, fuel and supply chains have been impacted by uncertainty because

of conflicts in different parts of the world, and said democratic values and the market economy make India and Belgium natural partners. He also highlighted new opportunities presented by India's economy in this challenging environment.

"Defence and security cooperation

continued on →P9

**'INDIA IS WAITING
FOR COMPARATIVE
TARIFF ADVANTAGE
TO SEAL U.S. DEAL'**

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: Commerce minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday that finalisation of the interim Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) with the US awaits a tariff structure that gives India a comparative advantage over its competitors. "As soon as the US is able to give us the preferential rate in comparison to our competition, we will finalise the BTA and announce the final details," he said. **→P2**

**3 YRS ON, MANIPUR
STRIFE TOLL AT 306;
49 REMAIN MISSING;
MINISTER TO HOUSE**

Thomas Ngangom

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IMPHAL: At least 306 people have been killed, and 49 are still missing in the ethnic violence that broke out in May 2023, Manipur home minister Govind Konthoujam informed the state's legislative assembly on Thursday. The minister was responding to a query by Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) legislator Sapam Ranjan Singh. **→P6**

Rapid warming

+2.2°C to +2.6°C
Nino 3.4 index reading, late July to mid-August (up from +1.5°C in May-July)

8°C above normal

Subsurface ocean temperatures in parts of the tropical Pacific in July and early August

WHY THIS ONE STANDS OUT

First WMO update on the phenomenon to be called "unequivocal" in the agency's 55-year history. Peak intensity forecast: very strong

WHAT INDIA CAN EXPECT
Limited impact on the withdrawing southwest monsoon
Weaker northeast monsoon likely
Warmer-than-normal winter, with reduced rainfall

100% chance of El Nino lasting till Feb '27: WMO

Jasveer Gandhiook

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NEW DELHI: El Nino has firmly established itself and will intensify into a "very strong" event over the coming months, the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) said on Thursday, with a near 100% likelihood that it will persist through February 2027—raising the risk of floods, drought and extreme heat across large parts of the world. For India, this may translate to a milder winter with reduced rains for Rabi crops, experts said.

Forecasters from WMO's Global Producing Centres indicate an exceptionally high likelihood of nearly 100% that El Nino will persist through to February 2027, the agency said, adding that this was the first time a WMO update on the phenomenon had been "so unequivocal", reflecting strong agreement across its forecasting network. Fueled by exceptionally warm ocean conditions across the tropical Pacific, El Nino is expected to strengthen further and peak towards the end of this year, with climate impacts continuing well into 2027, the update said.

Sea surface temperatures continued on →P9

IRAN TARGETS U.S. BASE IN KUWAIT AS IT MOURNS VICTIMS OF STRIKE

DUBAI: Iranian mourners carried caskets on Thursday at a funeral for victims of a US airstrike said to have struck a wedding party, and Tehran launched missiles and drones overnight at a US base in Kuwait, after the war's biggest escalation in more than a month. Iranian officials say four people died and nearly 70 were wounded by a strike that hit a home during a wedding. State TV reported on Thursday that a fifth person, a 22-year-old woman, had since died in hospital. The US military said it was aware of the Iranian reports but maintained that it "never targets civilians". **→P11**

VIDIA TO BUY HUGGINGFACE FOR \$13 BILLION

NEW YORK: Nvidia Corp. has agreed to acquire artificial intelligence startup Hugging Face in a transaction valued at about \$13 billion. The price includes an up to \$1 billion equity-based retention program for Hugging Face employees that join Nvidia. The chipmaker giant said it will keep Hugging Face's platform open and consistent with the startup's existing practices. **→P2**

MISSING NUMBERS SPIKE AT HYDROPROJECT SITES

Firms operating different hydropower projects in Nepal released updated counts of missing workers as rescuers worked on a war footing to save them

MISSING PEOPLE

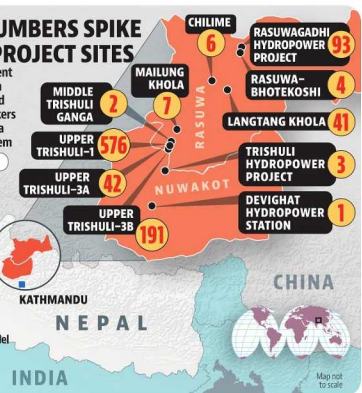
966

People still untraced, according to the firms. Nepal's authorities estimated the number at "around 900".

FOUR-PRONCED RESCUE EFFORT

The concentration of the missing has forced Nepal to run what are four parallel rescue operations, each led by a different combination of armies.

Related story on page 7



CAPITAL'S GARBAGE CRISIS PILES UP AMID CONTRACT TANGLE

Paras Singh

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NEW DELHI: Even as the Delhi government's cleanliness drive is underway, large parts of the Capital are drowning in garbage. The problem of overspilling dialys is linked to a bureaucratic and legal tangle surrounding the transition to new long-term contracts for garbage disposal.

DELHI EX-MINISTER JAIN GETS BAIL IN STP TENDER CASE

Arnabjit Sur

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NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Thursday granted bail to Delhi's former minister Satyendra Jain in a sewage treatment plants (STPs) tender case, saying, the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) "rushed in to arrest him" without gathering sufficient proof.

FLIGHT DIVERTED AFTER PILOT FACES MEDICAL ISSUE

NEW DELHI: A Mayday call signalling a life-threatening emergency was made after one of the pilots of a Doha-Bengaluru IndiGo flight became incapacitated, prompting its diversion to Muscat on Thursday. Officials said the matter said the pilot required urgent medical attention and that flight 6E 1302 landed safely. **→P8**

ESTONIA MINISTER EXITS OVER DEAL FOR SHELLS WITH INDIA-LINKED FIRM

NEW DELHI: Estonia's defence minister Hanno Pevkur resigned following a row over a botched EU-funded deal to buy artillery shells for Ukraine from a firm owned by an Indian entity, which denied allegations of wrongdoing. Estonian newspaper Eesti Ekspress reported Estonia in 2024 made a shells deal with Italy-registered firm Datasol SRL, owned by Indian company Neco Defence Munitions, but faced delivery issues. **→P11**

31-member JPC set up to examine FCRA bill

Saubhadra Chatterji

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NEW DELHI: Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Thursday constituted a 31-member joint committee of Parliament (JPC) to review the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, more than three weeks after the proposal to send the controversial legislation to a parliamentary panel was accepted in the Lower House.

A Lok Sabha bulletin added that Bharatiya Janata Party law-

maker Sanjay Jaiswal, a four-term MP from Bihar, is the chairperson of the panel. The panel has 14 BJP MPs, including Jaiswal, and a total of 19 National Democratic Alliance lawmakers.

The Congress has five berths. The Samajwadi Party, Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) and Indian Union Muslim League have one member each. The Trinamool Congress (Jai Prakash Mukherjee) and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam have two members each in the panel.

continued on →P9

{ GLORIA STEINEM } 1934-2026

Feminist icon who reshaped the fight for equality



Gloria Steinem in 1985

Reuters

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NEW YORK: Gloria Steinem, the American writer, lecturer, activist and organizer who fought for gender equality and women's civil and reproductive rights for more than five decades, has died, her foundation said. She was 92 years old.

The co-founder and consulting editor of Ms. Magazine championed the feminist move-

ment from the late 1960s onwards and inspired generations of women.

She died on Wednesday, her foundation said in an Instagram post on Thursday.

"From reluctant spokesperson to a beacon of positive change, hers is a singular journey, an American leader who can speak to us all," film and theatre director Julie Taymor said of Steinem in a 2017 New York

Times article.

THE INDIA YEARS THAT SHAPED A TRAILBLAZER
Feminist stalwart Gloria Steinem also had a deep association with India, where she encountered and absorbed many foundational ideas that later shaped her work. Long before Steinem became one of the most visible advocates for women's rights, she was a young American woman in her early 20s in Delhi, where she spent part of her time as a student at Miranda House. **→P2**

SPOT THE LIC AGENT IN THIS PICTURE

**WE BET YOU CAN'T
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PAGE ONE PLUS

NUMBER THEORY

PART 2

Is SIR cleaning up rolls or disenfranchising voters?

By Abhishek Jha and Roshan Kishore

The first part of this series looked at the key numbers from the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) results. The larger question, however, remains. What exactly is driving these results? A definite answer is not easy, especially because India's last published Census figures, from 2011, are now obsolete. The concluding part of this series will try to juxtapose some numbers and arrive at possible explanations.



READ: SIR's cut 118m so far. More than Brazil's '22 poll turnout

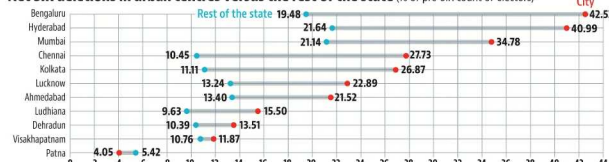


1 Higher deletions in larger urban centers support theories of duplicate entries in elector rolls

Delhi's draft SIR roll has underlined a theory HT first proposed in a story on March 2. India's largest urban centers, which are also likely to receive the highest number of migrants, have seen relatively larger deletions from rolls in SIR.

This could well be due to the fact that many workers were registered as voters in their native places as well as their place of migration, and chose to retain the former registration when SIR forced them to make a choice.

Net SIR deletions in urban centers versus the rest of the state (% of pre-SIR count of electors)

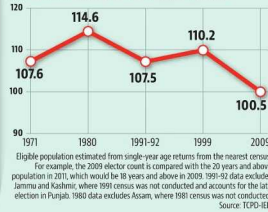


Change for Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Mumbai, Ludhiana, Dehradun, and Visakhapatnam is up to the draft roll; for Lucknow and Ahmedabad up to the final SIR roll; and for Chennai, Kolkata, and Patna up to the roll used in their latest assembly election. Mumbai and Bengaluru include all constituent districts. Source: EC

2 But an exact confirmation or rejection of this theory requires latest population data

Here is a rather contrarian and provocative take on the entire SIR controversy. If voters were indeed registered in more than one constituency and the SIR is actually getting rid of a lot of duplication, then it also means that India's adult population is lower than what we believe it to be. While this is not to discount possible wrongful deletions during SIR, if all 118 million were being deleted wrongly, it should have led to protests across the country. A comparison of India's previous electoral rolls with elector count in the closest election supports this theory, as the number of electors has always been higher than the voting-age population. The gap did reduce in the 2009 election cycle, which followed an SIR exercise between 2002 and 2004 and drives to increase Electors Photo Identity Card (EPIC) coverage.

Registered electors in Lok Sabha elections as % of eligible population estimated from the nearest census



Eligible population estimated from single-year age returns from the nearest census. For example, the 2009 election count is compared with the 20 years and above population in 2011, which would be 30 years and above in 2009. 1991-20 data excludes Jammu and Kashmir, where 1991 census was not conducted and accounts for the late election in Punjab. 1980 data excludes Assam, where 1981 census was conducted. Source: TPO-ED

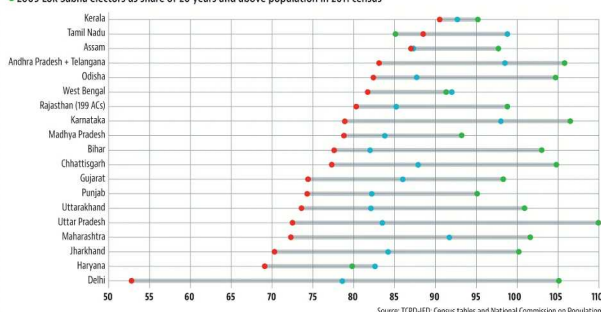
3 Right now most states show a lower-than-estimated population voter count for even pre-SIR electors

This is the most perplexing part about the data. If the logic is that another SIR was needed to purge the rolls of deadweight entries, then the pre-SIR rolls should have shown a higher number of electors than what comparable adult population projections suggest. But all 20 states and UTs for

which a projection is available show a lower number of pre-SIR voters than their estimated adult population. The gap has only increased in the post-SIR numbers, as is to be expected. In 2009, state-wise elector numbers diverged from the census population data on both sides.

The gap between elector rolls and population in India (Numbers in percent)

● Pre-SIR electors as share of projected 2026 adult population
● 2009 Lok Sabha electors as share of 20 years and above population in 2011 census



What do all these numbers mean? Some of the deletions in SIR are entirely natural, such as those of people who have died. Some might be rooted in socio-economic factors, such as marriage and migration for work. Some might indeed be wrongful exclusions because of institutional oversight or the sheer scale of the exercise. We will

never be able to know their exact shares. But in a situation where most states were already reporting lower numbers of electors than population projections suggest; another possibility cannot be ruled out: India's adult population may be lower than the projections suggest. We will have to wait for the 2027 Census data to solve the mystery.

{ SPORT } OVERTAKES MITHALI RAJ

Smriti Mandhana becomes highest woman run-scorer



Indian batting stalwart and women's team vice-captain Smriti Mandhana scripted history on Thursday by overtaking legendary compatriot Mithali Raj to become the highest run-scorer in women's international cricket across all formats. The 30-year-old reached the landmark during India's Women's Asia Cup 2026 Group A clash against Hong Kong at the Dubai International Stadium on Thursday. Mandhana scored a 64-ball 124-run knock, surpassing Mithali Raj's tally of 10,688 runs, and helping India win by 137 runs.

{ MY INDIA } AID TO SCHOOLS

'Schools ensured nat'l song is sung in full after warning'



Schools in West Bengal started ensuring that the national song is sung in full after the state government threatened to stop aid, chief minister Suvedu Adhikari said on Thursday. "We made it mandatory to sing all six stanzas of 'Vande Mataram' in schools. Initially there were objections. I said the government aid will be stopped. Then they budged," Adhikari said during an event in Kolkata. "I asked the education secretary to send me videos of schools. I noticed that everyone stood, but not all lips were moving. I told they have to move their lips too." mtc

Chronicling the India chapter of feminist pioneer's journey

Paras Singh

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NEW DELHI: Gloria Steinem, an American journalist, author and activist who was one of the most enduring faces of the feminist movement and the face of the reproductive and civil rights of women in the US, has died, her foundation announced Thursday.

Steinem also had a deep association with India, where she encountered and absorbed many foundational ideas that later shaped her work. Long before Steinem became one of the most visible advocates for women's rights, she was a young American woman in her early 20s in Delhi, trying to work out what to do with her life.

In 1956, shortly after graduating from Smith College, Steinem arrived in India on a Chester Bowles Asian Fellowship. She spent part of her time in Delhi as a student at Miranda House, then a relatively unusual destination for a young American woman travelling alone.

"Her association with Miranda House began during her formative years when she spent a year at the college. Her experience in India and her time at the college left a lasting impression on her worldview and her subsequent journey as a feminist and social activist," said the college, which also held a condolence meet on Thursday.

At Miranda House, her classmates taught her to wear a sari and navigate city buses. She took up odd jobs to support herself, including helping design sandals, writing promotional material and doing modelling assignments. She also featured as the face of a DCM (Delhi Cloth Mill) nylon sari advertisement.

But it was outside the classroom that India left its deepest mark. Steinem became associated with MN Roy's Radical Humanists and travelled with Gandhian activists. She worked in villages in what is now Tamil Nadu, alongside people involved in Vinoba Bhave's Bhodan movement, which sought to persuade landowners to give land to the landless. Her India experience exposed her to poverty, caste, inequality and grassroots organising.

For days, she trudged from village to village, everywhere encountering stories of atrocities and violence. "But mostly we just listened. To my amazement, long and emotion-filled meetings often ended with village leaders pledging to take no revenge on caste groups whose

members had attacked their group in neighbouring villages," she wrote in her 2015 memoir, *My Life on the Road*.

In her Substack dated March 21, 2025, Steinem pulled an excerpt from her essay titled "Doing Sixty" from her 1995 book "Moving Beyond Words".

"When I reflect on the importance of India in my life, I think most of all of sitting on a New Delhi veranda in the 1970s, drinking tea with Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, whose first name was (and is) enough to identify her in many countries of the world. Biographical dictionaries list her as 'freedom fighter, social worker, writer'."

In the 1950s, when I first met her, she was also in her fifties and already a legend for her leading role in the Freedom Struggle with Gandhi and Nehru—an activism for which she spent five years in British jails—and for her pioneering of the Indian handicraft movement.

Our meeting was arranged by my oldest friend in India, Devaki Jain, because we wanted to ask Kamaladevi's advice. Since Gandhi's nonviolent tactics were so well suited to women's movements around the world, we were thinking of studying his letters and writings, distilling what was most useful, and creating a kind of Gandhian/feminist handbook," she wrote.

Steinem shot to fame in America in the 1960s as a journalist, a writer, a political activist and a very different version of her. In January 2014, at 79, she returned to the India



Gloria Steinem in 1979. Two decades earlier, shortly after graduating from Smith College, Steinem arrived in India on a Chester Bowles Asian Fellowship. AP

mentator on issues such as prostitution, human trafficking and pornography. In 1971, she founded Ms. magazine, a feminist publication that focused on problems faced by women. She founded the National Women's Political Caucus in 1971 and later the Coalition of Labor Union Women and the Women's Media Center and Voters for Choice, which was aimed at promoting policies to maintain safe, legal and accessible abortion services for women.

In Delhi in 2007, she recalled spending two years in the country in the 1950s, saying that what she learned there remained a continuous influence throughout her life.

Steinem continued her involvement with Ruchira Gupta's Apne Aap Women Worldwide organisation, which works with trafficked women and children. While talking to Mint in 2014, she said that she was excited by the movement in the wake of the December 16, 2012 gang rape case. "It's what I love about India. The people will put up with only so much and then it will all erupt as they say 'Enough'," she said.

"While laws are important, change must begin from the family. Human beings are profoundly sensitive to context. So patriarchal families will produce patriarchal sons and daughters who will be submissive," she also said.

More than five decades after young Steinem arrived in Delhi, the city hosted a very different version of her. In January 2014, at 79, she returned to the India

International Centre to launch "As If Women Matter: The Essential Gloria Steinem Reader". The event brought together with some of India's leading feminists, including Ela Bhatt, Devaki Jain and Ruchira Gupta.

Steinem was born on March 25, 1934, in Toledo, Ohio, the second of two children to Leo Steinem, an itinerant antiques dealer, and Ruth Nuneviller, a journalist who was the first editor-in-chief of the school newspaper at the University of Toledo.

Her parents separated when she was 10, and Steinem lived with and cared for her mother, who had suffered several nervous breakdowns. After graduating from Western High School in Washington, Steinem attended Smith College in Northampton, Massachusetts, where she studied government. On her way to India, aged 22, and recently having broken off an engagement, Steinem had an illegal abortion, she recounted in *My Life on the Road*.

Steinem was a leader of the so-called Second Wave of feminism, which started in the 1960s. After women in the US fought for, and won, the right to vote in 1920, Second Wave feminists sought economic and social equality in areas ranging from sexuality to the labour market.

But she faced criticism for her association with CIA. She acknowledged that a youth festival she had organised was largely funded by the agency but defended her motives.

Seven decades have passed since that time and her apartment has been her home in New York for all these decades. Her work, her writings, her lifestyle are all so consistent: a sincere, deep regard for "difference", for humility – all wrapped in an amazingly rich intellect. We might have her passing, but to my mind, she has laid the foundation for the public acknowledgement of women's mind, skills, political and social voices.

Devaki Jain is an economist and writer who was awarded the Padma Bhushan for her contribution to feminist economics and social justice. The views expressed are personal

Meeting Gloria, in the afterglow of freedom

Devaki Jain

letters@hindustantimes.com

INCREDIBLE AS IT MIGHT appear, I met Gloria Steinem in 1956 at the home of one of the three young men who had built post-independence institutions such as the Cottage Industries Emporium—Lakshmi Jain, Som Benegal and DD Joshi. There were 30 bachelors aged around 30 or less, living in a lovely apartment in Connaught Place. The rare private apartment was an offer by another one of those who had jumped aboard the wave of post-independence service to enable the refugees of Partition to be rehabilitated—Dr Shanti

GLORIA LAID THE FOUNDATION FOR THE PUBLIC RECOGNITION OF WOMEN'S MIND, SKILLS, POLITICAL AND SOCIAL VOICES

Ghosh.

The post-independence atmosphere in Delhi was like a celebration, as so many people had jumped in to build so many of the institutions that we see and favour today. Visitors to India were eager to know more about this great revival, and thus to meet any of those

engaged in this reconstruction. One such area was the revival of handicrafts and, my "boy friend" at that time, Lakshmi Jain, was a star sought out by these foreigners. So a mutual friend had brought Gloria to LC Jain's habit in 1956; Gloria and I met and it was like magic. We decided to "hang out" together and wandered in Delhi, especially Old Delhi, talking and playing Holi when that happened and so on. While this aspect of her opinion is not well known, Gandhi and his ideas deeply impressed her. So when I visited New York in 1958, we went to the Gandhi statue together and laid flowers.

Seven decades have passed since that time and her apartment has been her home in New York for all these decades. Her work, her writings, her lifestyle are all so consistent: a sincere, deep regard for "difference", for humility – all wrapped in an amazingly rich intellect. We might have her passing, but to my mind, she has laid the foundation for the public acknowledgement of women's mind, skills, political and social voices.

Exam controller 'altered' OMR sheets to help KPSC candidates

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BENGALURU: IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar who was serving as the examination controller of Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) allegedly played a central role in manipulating the veterinary officer recruitment process, with investigators now examining evidence that he helped candidates who paid money to secure higher marks and better positions, and officials in the know on Thursday.

PROBE FOUND THAT GANGWAR ALLEGEDLY HAD ACCESS TO QUESTIONS BEFORE THE EXAMINATION AND LATER INTERFERED WITH CANDIDATES' OMR SHEETS

and Kannale, a CID team led by a DySP searched several banks in Bidar on Wednesday and obtained transaction records from accounts held in the names of Kannale's relatives and friends. Investigators suspect that money received from candidates was first moved through accounts belonging to Kannale's relatives before being transferred to Gangwar and some KPSC members.

"Document verification has been conducted at some branches of Bhalki's Om Lakshmi Sahaadha Sahakari Sangha and a nationalised bank in Bengaluru. We have disclosed details of transactions in the bank accounts of Kannale and Gangwar," a CID official said.

The alleged role of Gangwar is being examined against a wider investigation into the recruitment of 400 veterinary officers. Seven more candidates questioned by the CID on Tuesday reportedly admitted to paying money to obtain appointments. Investigators said the amounts allegedly demanded from candidates varied from Rs 40 lakh to Rs 80 lakh, with some making advance payments and others paying after the recruitment process.

The CID is also examining whether similar manipulation took place in other KPSC recruitments. Eight candidates selected for 'B' Group posts have been issued notices to appear for questioning. Documents recovered during a search of Kannale's residence in Sanjay Nagar included

admit cards connected with the 2025 'B' Group recruitment examination, while photographs of Kannale with candidates selected for DySP posts were also found, investigators said.

Among the 29 candidates accused of paying lakhs of rupees to secure veterinary officer appointments is Soguresh Jaka, a relative of former KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S. Sahu. Jaka allegedly secured 456.75 marks despite having failed two degree examinations before clearing them through compartment examinations.

The agency is also examining Kannale's financial dealings. Investigators found that he had allegedly recently acquired 15 acres of land in Bhalki and a commercial complex and had bought a car for his father. His overseas travel and businesses identified as the Bhagwat Group and AK Tours and Travels are also being examined.

Kannale's position as a Syndicate member of Tumakuru University has also come under the CID's examination. He was appointed to the university body in August 2025. Investigators sought records from the acting vice-chancellor regarding his appointment and tenure.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar has alleged that BJP and NDA leaders were connected to the KPSC irregularities and said information gathered by the Home Department would soon be disclosed. "Information has been received about the connections of BJP leaders in the KPSC irregularities. The information with the Home Minister against NDA leaders will be disclosed soon," Shivakumar said.

He added, "There should also be an investigation into who was in contact with the BJP leaders. All irregularities will come out of the investigation. The report from the Governor and the issues related to the investigation have been discussed and approved in the cabinet. Further action will be taken based on the investigation."

IAS officer suspended after arrest over KPSC recruitment exam row

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government on Thursday suspended IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar after his arrest in a case involving alleged corruption in recruitment conducted by the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC), officials said.

Gangwar, a 2016 batch IAS officer serving as Director of MSME, was arrested on August 30. He was taken into police custody on August 31 for further investigation.

The government stated that his detention for more than 48 hours for alleged corruption constituted a "gross violation of Rule 3 of the All India Services (Conduct) Rules, 1968".

An order issued by T Mahanthesh, under secretary to Government in the Department of Personnel and Administrative Reforms, said, "Therefore, in exercise of the powers conferred under Rule 3(2) read with 3(3) of the All India Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1969, Sri Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar, IAS (KN 2016), is placed under suspension with immediate effect and until further orders, pending further investigation by the Criminal Investigation Department."

The government directed "the officer shall not leave the headquarters under any circumstances without the written permission of the state government". Gangwar will receive a subsistence allowance under Rule 4 of the All India Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1969, during his suspension.

After his arrest, Gangwar

GOVT DIRECTED THAT 'THE OFFICER SHALL NOT LEAVE THE HEADQUARTERS UNDER ANY CIRCUMSTANCES'

"was produced before the jurisdictional magistrate and was remanded to judicial custody on August 30". He was taken into police custody on August 31 for further investigation.

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Govt withdraws parks bill after protests in Lalbagh

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BENGALURU: The state cabinet has withdrawn Karnataka Government Parks (Preservation) (Amendment) Bill, 2026, following protests on plans to build a tunnel beneath Lalbagh, officials said on Thursday.

Deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said that the Cabinet has decided to take back the Bill and place a revised version before the public before returning it to the Assembly.

The retreat came days after thousands gathered at Lalbagh to oppose the legislation and the proposed tunnel road. The project would require about six acres of Lalbagh temporarily and another acre permanently.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar said, "Our government has always respected the sentiments of the people of Karnataka. The Cabinet's decision to withdraw the Karnataka Parks Conservation Amendment Bill is also a reflection of this commitment towards the people. Talking into consideration public opinion, concerns and sentiments, the government has decided to present its intentions more clearly before the people and reintroduce the Bill with the necessary amendments. In a democracy, the people are the ultimate judges. It is the resolve of our government to honestly reiterate our intentions before the court of public opinion and move forward with people's trust."

The amendment had cleared the Legislature on August 24 and was sent to the Governor. It would have permitted government to use public spaces, bodies, public sector companies and local authorities to use as much as 5% of protected parkland for public utilities.

It also contained provisions for retrospective approval of certain infrastructure and utility projects. That provision became the focus of the dispute over Lalbagh.

Environmental organisations and citizen groups argued that allowing protected green areas to be diverted, even within a stated limit, could create a route for infrastructure projects inside parks.

The government, however, said the measure was designed for public infrastructure and not for opening parks to private construction.

Parameshwara said the proposed Lalbagh tunnel was



The retreat came days after thousands gathered at Lalbagh to oppose the legislation and the proposed tunnel road. The project would require about six acres of Lalbagh temporarily and another acre permanently.

among the purposes behind the provision. "The purpose was not to snatch parks. The purpose was to acquire land for the tunnel road project. They could have had a debate, suggested changes or diversions, instead they politicised it," he said.

The Bill had been passed alongside the BMLTA (Amendment) Bill during the previous Assembly session without substantive debate. Parameshwara said that the government would now collect objections and suggestions before deciding how the legislation should be framed. "We will put it in the public domain for discussion and reintroduce the Bill in the next session with amendments," he said.

The government will also notify the Governor about its decision, Parameshwara further said.

The dispute had spilled beyond the Assembly and into Lalbagh, where citizens, environmental activists, resident welfare associations and public figures assembled for the "Walk in Lalbagh. Walk for Lalbagh" campaign. The gathering was led by retired Indian Forest Service (IFS) officer and environmentalist AN Yellappa Reddy.

Protesters called for the withdrawal of the Bill and opposed plans involving a tunnel shaft, a multi-level parking facility and commercial structures. They also sought "Construction Free Zone" status for Lalbagh.

Particular concern centred on the park's ancient Peninsular Gneiss rock. Protesters questioned what underground works, tunnelling and the use of heavy machinery could mean for the geological formation and the wider ecosystem.

The demonstrations also

sharpened questions over the government's handling of the legislation. The Bill was passed a day after billionaire Gautam Adani met chief minister DK Shivakumar. An Adani owned company is expected to obtain the contract for the tunnel road. Shivakumar had said two days before Thursday's Cabinet decision that the government would reconsider the amendment amid the protests.

Parameshwara defended the government's decision to withdraw the legislation while saying the Opposition had failed to engage with it during the Assembly session.

"Last session, we brought a Bill to amend the Act. A total of 5% of the land was to be used for public purposes. There was no discussion on this. Opposition parties did not participate in this. They politicised it and conveyed the wrong idea to the public of what it means," he said.

He said lawmakers could have sought changes or explanations before the Bill was passed. "They could have had a debate, advised us, proposed changes or sought clarifications," he said.

The government will now examine proposals on how parkland could be transferred. Parameshwara said suggestions had included lease, sale, gift and mortgage, but that each option would have to be assessed before a new Bill was prepared.

He also defended the government's conduct during the earlier Assembly session, saying protesters had disrupted proceedings. "They have a right to protest, but they disrupted the session. We had no other way to conduct some business in the House," he said.

Food safety officials inspect Blinkit facility after worm seen in egg

HT Correspondent
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BENGALURU: Food Safety officials inspected a Blinkit retail facility in Mangaluru after a consumer complained to Health Minister U T Khader that an egg purchased through the online platform was damaged and allegedly contained a worm, said a statement from the department.

Acting on the complaint, officials visited the Blinkit facility at Falnir Square in Falnir and found packets containing brown eggs during the inspection. The officials directed the personnel at the facility to immediately remove and dispose of the affected packets.

As a precautionary measure, the storage room was temporarily closed and sealed to facilitate cleaning and sanitisation of the area where food products were stored. The inspection followed a complaint submitted to the department by a consumer who said eggs ordered through

OFFICIALS DIRECTED THE PERSONNEL AT THE FACILITY TO REMOVE AND DISPOSE OF THE AFFECTED PACKETS

Blinkit were found damaged, with a worm reportedly discovered inside one of them.

The Food Safety Department said a notice would be issued to the Blinkit facility, seeking an explanation from its management over the incident. "Further action will be taken based on the findings and the response submitted by the concerned establishment," the department said.

Officials said the sealing of the storage area was intended to ensure that the facility underwent complete cleaning and sanitisation following the discovery of the damaged egg packets. Blinkit was not available for an immediate response.

Day 3 of BJP's 'Ballari Chalo Padayatra'



Karnataka BJP state president BY Vijayendra (centre), along with party leaders and workers, leads the third day of 'Ballari Chalo Padayatra' demanding the implementation of irrigation projects and protesting against the state government at Gadur village in Koppal district on Thursday.

Assembly to discuss Kasturirangan report, drought in spl session

HT Correspondent
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BENGALURU: Karnataka will convene a special session of the legislature from September 21 to 23 to address the state's severe drought, difficulties faced by farmers and the contentious Kasturirangan report, deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said on Thursday.

The Cabinet approved the three-day sitting, deciding that the drought in particular required a broader debate due to its effects beyond farming. Parameshwara said the crisis was affecting the state's economy and food security and that legislators had insufficient opportunities to discuss the problems confronting farmers.

"The Cabinet has decided to hold a special session on September 21, 22 and 23. The farmers of the state are facing difficulties due to several ongoing issues, and there have not been enough opportunities to discuss these matters in the House," he said.

"This year, the state is facing a severe drought. After nearly 150 years, such a drought has happened. Its impact is not only on the lives of farmers but also on the wider community of the state, including the economy and food security. Therefore, we want to have a detailed discussion on these issues, and that is why we are holding this special session," Parameshwara added.

The government has named eight ministers as its official spokespersons, including Parameshwara, Krishna Byre Gowda, Priyank Kharge, Santosh Lad, U T Khader, Anand Chandre, K B Balakrishna and Lakshman Savadi.

They will receive daily briefings from government departments and respond to media queries using it.

and arguments for and against the report continue. Therefore, once and for all, we want to inform the people about the issue and have a detailed discussion on it. We will also use this special session for the purpose of discussing the Kasturirangan Report," he said.

The Cabinet also approved a 10-member group of ministers committed to examine important matters before placing them before the Cabinet. Chief minister DK Shivakumar will chair the panel, which includes Parameshwara, K H Muniyappa, K H George, Priyank Kharge, Krishna Byre Gowda, Yathindra Siddaramaiah, U T Khader, Lakshman Savadi, Santosh Lad and MB Patil.

"For the first time in Karnataka, a Group of Ministers Committee has been constituted. Before that, important decisions were taken by bringing them to the Cabinet, certain matters will be discussed and deliberated upon in this committee," Parameshwara said.

He added the arrangement would also address complaints that decisions were sometimes taken by the CM without adequate consultation. "There have been comments that when the chief minister takes a decision alone, people say, 'The CM is taking decisions on his own, without consulting or discussing them with anyone.' That is why this committee has been constituted," Parameshwara said.

The government has named eight ministers as its official spokespersons, including Parameshwara, Krishna Byre Gowda, Priyank Kharge, Santosh Lad, U T Khader, Anand Chandre, K B Balakrishna and Lakshman Savadi.

They will receive daily briefings from government departments and respond to media queries using it.

DAUGHTER OF BJP MLA ACCUSED OF ASSAULTING COP DENIED BAIL

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MANDYA: A local court in Karnataka's Mandya district has rejected the bail plea of BJP MLA Suresh Gowda's daughter, who is accused of assaulting and assaulting a woman police sub-inspector following a dispute at a temple last month.

The Third Additional Sessions Court at Srirangapatna rejected the bail plea of the accused, Aishwarya, recently.

Aishwarya is accused of slapping the woman sub-inspector. The alleged incident took place on August 12 at the Maramma Temple in Ukkadur during Bhima Amavasya celebrations.

The woman police officer duty at the temple has alleged in her complaint that Aishwarya, who is married to an Assistant Commissioner at Srirangapatna, sought permission to enter the sanctum sanctorum directly without standing in the queue.

When the SI asked her to wait to get into the queue, Aishwarya allegedly identified herself as the MLA's daughter and questioned why she was being stopped.

The argument allegedly escalated, with Aishwarya abusing and hitting the woman police sub-inspector on the head. Based on the SI's complaint, Kyanmahalli police registered a case under relevant sections of BNS for assaulting a public servant, causing simple hurt, intentional insult and criminal intimidation against the MLA's daughter.

THE COP ALLEGED THAT AISHWARYA ASKED FOR PERMISSION TO SKIP THE QUEUE AT THE TEMPLE

Govt okays ₹25 cr for fodder aid in drought-hit areas

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka Cabinet on Thursday sanctioned ₹25 crore for fodder-related measures in drought-hit areas and approved the allocation of 4,500 electric buses to Bengaluru and other parts of the state.

It also cleared a slew of measures covering agriculture, healthcare, infrastructure, education and regional connectivity. The Cabinet approved the fodder allocation for purchase and distribution of fodder seed kits through the animal husbandry department.

The department can procure fodder from outside the state as well as from farmers who have grown it.

On the electric buses, deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said 4,500 buses of different types have been sanctioned under the Centre's PM e-DRIVE

programme, with tenders already called and decisions taken for six companies.

"There is no contribution from us in this. They will allocate them to the state. Maintenance and all that will be our responsibility," he briefed reporters after the Cabinet meeting.

The buses will be deployed in Bengaluru as well as other parts of Karnataka, with the state government deciding their distribution. The cost of each bus is expected to be between ₹2 crore and ₹15 crore, Parameshwara said.

The Cabinet also approved measures to address the continuing drought situation, with 101 taluks already declared drought-hit based on the Centre's Drought Manual 2020.

Another 50-60 taluks may qualify in the second round, with the government expected to complete the process in the coming days.

Parameshwara said the state would prepare a memorandum on drought losses and submit it to the Centre later this month. Last year, Karnataka had estimated losses of ₹39,000 crore and sought ₹18,000 crore from the Centre, but received ₹3,500 crore after approaching the Supreme Court, he said.

So far, ₹1,229 crore has been sanctioned under the State Disaster Response Programme, though the amount has not yet been released, Parameshwara said.

The state has been meeting immediate requirements from its own resources, including ₹187 crore for drinking water and ₹329 crore kept with Deputy Commissioners for drinking water works under in eligible drought-hit taluks, he explained.

Overall, the situation is very serious this time, Parameshwara said, adding that rainfall by the second week of September could

provide some relief in terms of water and fodder availability.

The Cabinet approved an Export Promotion Programme for agricultural and horticultural produce, with the Karnataka State Agricultural Produce Processing and Export Corporation proposing to spend ₹59 crore over three years on financial assistance to exporters, market facilities and quality assurance.

A comprehensive trauma care programme to digitally integrate 182 government hospitals, comprising 47 taluk hospitals and 135 community health centres.

The system will help patient registration, treatment, diagnosis and pharmacy services.

A comprehensive trauma care programme was also cleared at an estimated cost of about ₹46 crore, including 100 Basic Life Support ambulances, three CT scan machines and 13 portable devices for detecting

brain injuries.

The Cabinet approved development of Viseswargay College of Engineering (VUCE), Bengaluru, on the lines of an IIT at a cost of ₹249 crore. The project will be funded from around ₹600 crore recently returned to Viseswargay Technological University (VTU) after a legal dispute.

It also approved a ₹2,000-crore government guarantee to the Karnataka State Cooperative Agriculture and Rural Development Bank for refinancing through NABARD during 2026-27.

Infrastructure approvals including ₹137.92 crore in principle for widening a road in Madur, with the road and land acquisition components referred to a technical committee for reconsideration.

A bridge costing about ₹70 crore was also approved in Kaggwad taluk of Bagalur district in the meeting.

T'gana n' minister sacked over daughter's remarks

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HYDERABAD: Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy on Thursday sacked state endowments and forests minister Konda Surekha from his cabinet, after the All-India Congress Committee (AICC) approved action against her on disciplinary grounds.

Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla on Thursday approved the chief minister's decision. On the advice of the Chief Minister of Telangana, the Governor of Telangana has dropped Konda Surekha, Minister from the Council of Ministers with immediate effect, a Lok Bhavan Press Communication said.

Surekha was served a show-cause notice on August 20 by the disciplinary committee of the Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee, seeking an explanation for her daughter Konda Sushmita's outburst against the party in general and the chief minister in particular at a meeting in Warangal on August 19.

Surekha replied to the notice on the same day and also sent written explanations to AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and former general secretary KC Venugopal. However, the PC was not satisfied with her explanation and sent a report to the high command recommending action against her.

The top Congress leaders held discussions with Revanth Reddy, PCC chief Mahesh Kumar Goud and other state Congress leaders in New Delhi on Wednesday. Though Surekha also rushed to the national capital to present

KONDA SUREKHA | TELANGANA CONG MLA

I am not worried about my dismissal from the cabinet, but what hurt me was the way it was done, without even seeking my explanation.

HT

her case, she was not given the audience. On Thursday, AICC gave its approval to sack her from the cabinet, a PCC leader privy to the development said.

An official release from the Chief Minister's Office said the chief minister also ordered rescinding of the appointment of senior Congress leader and party in general and the chief minister in particular at a meeting in Warangal on August 19.

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and former MP G Sudha Rani as chairperson of the Kakatiya Urban Development Authority.

Surekha accuses CM of blackmail politics

Reacting strongly to the chief minister's decision to drop her from the cabinet, Surekha said the high command acted unilaterally without seeking her explanation. She questioned why she was being held responsible for remarks made by her daughter, when she did not have any independent opinion.

"I am not worried about my dismissal from the cabinet, but what hurt me was the way it was done, without even seeking my explanation," Surekha said, speaking to reporters at her residence in Hyderabad.

She also said she had no reason to condemn her daughter's comments, arguing that she did not have the authority to question or disown her daughter's personal opinion. Surekha released a letter she had addressed to the Congress high command during a media

conference and questioned the action taken against other party leaders over their controversial remarks. "Why has no action been taken against the statement made by former MLA T Jagga Reddy and MLA Komatireddy Rajagopal Reddy against the chief minister in the past?"

She alleged that her removal from the cabinet was part of a larger conspiracy hatched by leaders close to the chief minister and also the latter's brothers. "These people also conspired against my followers, particularly my former officer on special duty (OSD) Sumanth and got him arrested in a fabricated case," she said.

"High command has no intention to remove me. I know that 100%. But, the chief minister indulged in blackmail politics saying he would go if I am not removed," she claimed.

Surekha asserted that she and others had been rising in politics through public support and were ultimately accountable to the people. She called upon Congress leaders who were unhappy with developments within the government and party to speak out. "Those leaders who are facing difficulties should come out and raise their voice. Speak up about what is happening in the government. Otherwise, there will be no option but to suffer the consequences,"

Surekha made it clear that she would remain with the Congress. "I will continue in the party. I will attend the assembly sessions as an MLA," she said.

Meanwhile, Chinnna Reddy said she would not be seeking any comment on being sacked from the post of state planning board vice-chairman.

TN to get new secretariat, Civic City, says Vijay

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government on Thursday announced its plans to establish a Tamil Nadu Olympic City and a new Assembly Secretariat Integrated complex for ₹1,200 crore in Chennai.

Making a slew of announcements under Rule 110 in the assembly, Vijay said the Tamil Nadu Olympic City would be established in Chennai on behalf of the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT). Vijay also unveiled his government's vision to establish, in Chennai, a new Secretariat Integrated complex for ₹1,200 crore and a Motor Sports City.

"This Olympic City will be developed as an integrated sports complex of Olympic standards. It will feature modern infrastructure including world-class sports arenas, state-of-the-art sports equipment, high performance training centre, sports medicine centres," Vijay said in the assembly, adding that it would be equipped with accommodation facilities for athletes and coaches.

Vijay noted that the Olympic City would serve as world-class sports hub on the borders of Chhattisgarh, which were once the bastions of outlawed Communist Party of India (Maoist), police said on Thursday.

The deceased was identified as Madam Nagawara Rao of Nagar Village in Venkatapuram mandal in the district. The along with the bodies of another man had gone into the forests on Karagattali hills to collect bamboo, a police officer from Venkatapuram told local reporters.

The officer said the incident happened at Beldegutta nearly 10 kilometres from their village. The tribals were returning to the forest after cutting the bamboo and carrying the stacks on their backs on Wednesday evening.

"While they were walking down the hills, Rao accidentally slipped and fell, which caused him to lose his footing and he fell into a deep ditch, where he was found dead," he said. "The other man was injured but he is recovering well."

"On getting the information, we rushed to the village and launched a probe into the incident," the officer said, adding, "the security forces were trying to find out whether there were any other landmines planted in the route."

Srinivasa Rao Apparau
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HYDERABAD: The Bollaram police in Hyderabad recovered 160 electric detonators stuffed in a plastic bucket at a private venture close to the firing range of the Madras Regiment in the Secunderabad Cantonment, officials said on Thursday.

This comes three days after weapons and ammunition were stolen from the cantonment. North Zone deputy commissioner of police Ch Sridhar told reporters that the detonators were found in Golf Enclave private area where the detonators were being carried out by some surrounding areas as part of investigation into the arms theft case at the regiment.

The private venture was close to the cantonment but was not part of any Army area. "The detonators are suspected to be used by some individuals who were carrying them long ago," he said.

Sridhar, however, said the



CM Vijay speaks in the House on Thursday.

In 1640 on a land purchased by the East India Company for commercial operations and construction was completed in 1644. The chief minister said the new Secretariat building will bring together and integrate all government departments into a single administrative campus. A modern administrative complex will be created adhering to fire safety features, accessibility for persons with disabilities and green building standards," the chief minister said.

The existing Secretariat at Fort St George would be preserved as historic monument, safeguarding the heritage value for future generations to learn from, he remarked.

Over the past 40 years, the chief minister said, the number of employees working in government departments has increased significantly and because the existing infrastructure remains largely unchanged, it has resulted in a point of stagnation. He pointed out that since the remaining land at Fort St George belongs to the Defence ministry and the ASI, additional construction and modernisation work cannot be undertaken.

Acknowledging that the Fort St George stands as a proud symbol of Tamil Nadu's administration, establishing a new, integrated Secretariat complex has become "essential" for future administrative growth of Tamil Nadu.

(With PTI inputs)

TN HOUSE URGES CENTRE TO MAKE TAMIL MADRAS HC MAIN LANGUAGE

S Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu assembly on Thursday unanimously adopted a resolution moved by chief minister C Joseph Vijay urging the Union government to recognise Tamil as the primary language at the Madras high court.

Vijay urged the Centre to establish the infrastructure required to deliver all high court judgements, decrees and court orders in Tamil and immediately initiate all necessary legal actions on proposals submitted by the State government under the judicial system reforms bill, 2023, which is under consideration of the Union government to take immediate and necessary action to facilitate the use of Tamil as the principal language of the High Court of Madras.

Maintaining that Tamil is not considered as a mere language but as an identity intertwined with emotions and life, Vijay said, "When it comes to Tamil, a distinct sense of passion awakens within."

Underlining that Tamil has already been established as the judicial language in the sessions courts, the chief minister said, "It has become an imperative need of the times that the Madras high court, the apex body of the state judicial system, should recognise Tamil as its primary language." He said the request was not against any language but a request that respects the diversity of India.

(With PTI inputs)

TELANGANA CEO ISSUED NOTICE BY BLO FOR NAME MISMATCH IN S.I.R

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HYDERABAD: Telangana CEO C Sudharshan Reddy was issued a notice by the BLO for name mismatch during the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls in the state.

Reddy told PTI on Thursday that he was issued the notice a week ago, and that he replied on September 2.

The notice stated that an anomaly with regard to the name, compared to the 2002 electoral roll was found and that a document to clarify the same be submitted.

Reddy said he had submitted his passport as the document for the clarification. Following the publication of the draft electoral roll on August 17 as part of Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the phase of issuing notices and disposal of Claims and Objections is currently underway in Telangana. The SIR was initiated on October 15. The final roll will be published on October 19.

AP ACB arrests TRD's deputy executive officer in DA case

Srinivasa Rao Apparau
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HYDERABAD: The Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) of Andhra Pradesh police on Thursday arrested the deputy executive officer of Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), that administrators Lord Venkateswara temple on Tirumala hills, in a disproportionate assets case following searches at his residence, office and the houses of his relatives, officials said.

Five teams of the ACB had conducted the searches at the locations linked to Mendu Lokanath, they began on Wednesday morning and went on till evening. ACB deputy superintendent of police in Tirupati, Madhavi Srinivasa Rao said, "Lokanath had amassed massive assets disproportionate to his known sources of income," he said.

After completing the searches, ACB officials took Lokanath into custody on Thursday morning and shifted him to the ACB office. "He was produced before the ACB court in Nellore for judicial remand," the DSP said.

During the searches 2kg of gold, 635kg of silver, ₹25 lakh in cash, four fixed deposits in Loka-nath and his son's names and property documents were seized.

The ACB also conducted searches at the residences of the accused officer's brothers-in-law. It also found a property document valued at ₹31.98 lakh, jointly held in the name of the accused officer's wife and others. "The ACB has provisionally estimated the total value of the assets identified so far at approximately ₹5 crore. But their market value is several times more than the document value," the DSP said.

According to Rao, the case was registered under the Criminal Procedure Code by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which investigated the alleged adulteration of ghee used in the making of Tirumala Laddu prasadam.

According to the ACB official, the CBI had completed its investigation into the ghee adulteration case and filed a charge sheet. During the searches 2kg of gold, 635kg of silver, ₹25 lakh in cash, four fixed deposits in Lokanath and his son's names and property documents were seized.

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TRIBAL MAN KILLED IN IED EXPLOSION AT T'GANA FORMER MAOIST BASTION

HYDERABAD: A 60-year-old tribal man was killed when a landmine exploded on Karagattali hills in Telangana's Nallamala forest on Thursday, police said on Thursday.

The deceased was identified as Madam Nagawara Rao of Nagar Village in Venkatapuram mandal in the district. The along with the bodies of another man had gone into the forests on Karagattali hills to collect bamboo, a police officer from Venkatapuram told local reporters.

The officer said the incident happened at Beldegutta nearly 10 kilometres from their village. The tribals were returning to the forest after cutting the bamboo and carrying the stacks on their backs on Wednesday evening.

"While they were walking down the hills, Rao accidentally slipped and fell, which caused him to lose his footing and he fell into a deep ditch, where he was found dead," he said. "The other man was injured but he is recovering well."

"On getting the information, we rushed to the village and launched a probe into the incident," the officer said, adding, "the security forces were trying to find out whether there were any other landmines planted in the route."

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government has taken up initiatives to collect DNA samples of first-degree relatives of the individuals who could not be traced after the flash floods in Nepal on August 26.

The government has urged the necessary arrangements to collect the willing relatives of the missing people to the nearest region — Chennai, Thangur and Madurai to collect the DNA samples free of cost and to upload the details onto the portal set up by the Government of Nepal.

The government has urged immediate family members — parents, sons, or daughters — of those missing in the flash floods to provide DNA (blood) samples to forensic laboratories in the three regions.

According to an official release on Thursday, out of the total 305 individuals from Tamil Nadu, 220 have been safely rescued and continuous efforts are underway to trace the remaining 85 people. "The government of Tamil Nadu is taking all necessary measures in coordination with the Centre, Government of Nepal and the Indian Embassy to safely rescue the missing people and bring them back to Tamil Nadu," the release said.

The government is extending all necessary assistance to relatives who have to travel to Nepal with these details.

160 detonators found in private venture near Madras Regiment

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HYDERABAD: The Bollaram police in Hyderabad recovered 160 electric detonators stuffed in a plastic bucket at a private venture close to the firing range of the Madras Regiment in the Secunderabad Cantonment, officials said on Thursday.

This comes three days after weapons and ammunition were stolen from the cantonment. North Zone deputy commissioner of police Ch Sridhar told reporters that the detonators were found in Golf Enclave private area where the detonators were being carried out by some surrounding areas as part of investigation into the arms theft case at the regiment.

The private venture was close to the cantonment but was not part of any Army area. "The detonators are suspected to be used by some individuals who were carrying them long ago," he said.

Sridhar, however, said the

POLICE SAID THAT THE DETONATORS ARE SUSPECTED TO BE USED BY LAND, PILOT DEVELOPERS AND KEPT THERE LONG AGO

Bollaram police registered a case under the Explosive Substances Act and launched an investigation to determine who placed the detonators at the location, when they were brought there and for what purpose.

According to another police officer, an Army Subedar had alerted the Bollaram police station on Wednesday after the detonators were noticed in an abandoned light-green plastic bucket in the private venture behind the firing range.

Police and Army personnel subsequently alerted the local disposal squad, which examined and seized the detonators. Pre-

liminary findings showed that the 160 electrical detonators had been arranged in eight bundles of 20 each. The police immediately seized the detonators with the help of a bomb disposal squad. We are trying to find out the source of the detonators," the officer said.

The bomb disposal squad has inspected the scene, while police are continuing searches in the surrounding areas and attempting to establish the source of the intended use of the detonators. Further probe is under way.

On August 31, an officer of the regiment lodged a complaint with the Bollaram police station that four AK-203 assault rifles, one INSAS rifle, seven pistols, a night-vision binocular and more than 400 rounds of ammunition had been stolen from the armoury late on Sunday.

A burglary case was registered following the complaint, and the police are conducting a search for the stolen weapons and ammunition.

Sabarimala gold theft: Ex-TDB chief gets bail

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A Vigilance court in Kollam on Thursday granted bail to former Travancore Devaswam Board (TDB) president PS Prasanth on medical grounds in the Sabarimala gold theft cases.

Alikumar, ex-member of the Travancore Devaswam Board, was the last team and arraigned along with Prasanth in the gold theft cases, has also been granted bail on health grounds. The 17th accused in the case, was arrested by the special investigation team (SIT) of the Kerala police on July 23.

While he was remanded to the district jail in Poojappura, he had been admitted to the Thiruvananthapuram Government Medical College hospital last week after he suffered a brain haemorrhage. In his petition, the former TDB chief's counsel argued that he required advanced medical care and therefore must be granted bail.

According to the remand report filed by the SIT before the court in Kollam, the TDB leadership, under Prasanth, approved the decision to send the gold-plated 'dwarapalakas' (guardian

idol) panels for re-plating to Smart Creations, a firm, in Chennai in September 2024. The decision was made overruling the recommendations of then Thiruvananthapuram commissioner of police (TDB) president PS Prasanth on medical grounds in the Sabarimala gold theft cases.

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HC junks Stalin's plea against TVK MLA's Kolathur seat win

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BENGALURU: The Madras high court on Thursday dismissed a plea filed by TVK MLA MK Stalin seeking a "100% counting of VVPAT slips" in the Kolathur assembly constituency and, consequently, a declaration that he was the duly elected candidate after nullifying TVK MLA VS Babu's election.

A bench of justice SA Dharmadhikari and justice G Arul Murugan held that Stalin's writ petition was not maintainable since the relief sought by him amounted, in substance, to a challenge to the election of the returned candidate. Such a challenge, the court said, can be made only through an election petition under the Representation of the People Act, 1951.

The high court also rejected the "attempt to frame the dispute as one concerning only the post-ratification of JDMs and VVPAT units." It noted that Stalin had sought not merely a false verification but also a declaration that Stalin's election was valid. The court said Stalin declared elected from Kolathur.

"These are reliefs that go to the very root of the election and its result," the Bench said, holding that "a prayer of this description is, in substance, nothing but a challenge to the correctness of the election" and was therefore barred by Article 329(b).

Article 329(b) bars courts from interfering in an election to Parliament or a State legislature except through election petition. "When a petitioner asks the court to declare a duly notified return void, and to declare himself elected in place of the returned candidate, he is doing precisely what Article 329(b) of the Constitution forbids him from doing," the court said.

The high court also relied on Sections 97 and 100 of the Representation of the People Act, Section 97 provides for rectification of an election when a candidate seeks a

declaration that he or she, rather than the returned candidate, was duly elected. The Bench said such a claim requires notice to other candidates and an opportunity to be given to the returned candidate to be heard by a trial involving oral and documentary evidence.

Stalin's own decision to array 33 other contesting candidates as respondents in the writ petition "tacitly recognises the need for such an exercise," the court held.

The court held that the allegations concerning malfunctioning VVPAT units during mock polling, alleged breaches relating to address tags and seals, and the non-detection of a ballot unit by a control unit were matters that could be raised as grounds in an election petition under Section 100 of the Act. Such allegations, it said, would have to be proved to the satisfaction of the court.

The court rejected Stalin's request for 100% counting of VVPAT slips and checking and sealing of the boxes. "Even if such an exercise was warranted, it could be ordered only by the election tribunal after the petitioner established a prima facie case through evidence," it said.

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government has taken up initiatives to collect DNA samples of first-degree relatives of the individuals who could not be traced after the flash floods in Nepal on August 26.

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Andhra cabinet clears key projects; directs steps to tackle El Nino

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AMARAVATI: Andhra Pradesh Cabinet on Thursday approved several key proposals, including major infrastructure projects in Amaravati and revival of drinking water schemes, besides directing the state to take measures to tackle the impact of El Nino in the state.

The decisions were taken at the 56th Cabinet meeting held under the chairmanship of Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu. The Cabinet approved several key proposals, including major infrastructure projects in Amaravati, the Andhra Pradesh Poultry Development Policy 2026-29 while also directing officials to take immediate measures to mitigate the impact of El Nino in the state. "Information and Public Relations Minister Kolu Sudharasathay said, participating a press conference.

He said Naidu had directed officials to ensure that not a single acre in the state suffers crop loss or is allowed to dry up due to the impact of El Nino. The minister said rainfall in the state was 52 percent below normal so far and Andhra Pradesh was among

MY INDIA

India ready to help end the war between Russia, Ukraine: Ex

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NEW DELHI: India stands ready to help in all efforts to end the war in Ukraine, external affairs minister S Jaishankar told the top Ukrainian leadership in Kyiv on Thursday, days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Russian President Vladimir Putin to move from "endless war to the end of war".

Peace efforts and the development of bilateral ties, including trade and investment, figured in discussions between the Ukrainian leadership and Jaishankar, the first external affairs minister to make a stand-alone visit to Kyiv. Jaishankar also visited Ukraine as part of the delegation that accompanied Modi on a trip two years ago.

Jaishankar's visit came against the backdrop of a significant increase in Russian attacks on merchant shipping in the Black Sea, which has led to the deaths of five Indian seafarers, and drone and missile strikes on cities across Ukraine. Jaishankar pointed to the death of an Indian national in an attack in Kyiv two days ago and said, "We join in mourning every life lost and convey our deepest sympathy to every affected family."

Jaishankar told a joint media briefing with Ukrainian foreign minister Andriy Bohdanovych that with



Ukrainian Minister Volodymyr Zelenskyy meets external affairs minister S Jaishankar in Kyiv on Thursday.

the war in its fifth year, India has maintained that this is "not an era of war", and solutions won't emerge from the battlefield.

He noted Modi had said at the meeting with Putin on the margins of the SCO Summit in Bangkok that "endless war must now give way to the end of war" and said every day of conflict will lead to more deaths and destruction. "Understandably, it is for the parties involved to find a way. But, if India can be of any help in any manner, we are ready, and this was the core of my discussion so far with foreign minister Svyatoslav", he said.

Jaishankar for visiting Ukraine amid "non-stop Russian strikes"

and said Kyiv is grateful to New Delhi for backing joint efforts to end the conflict. "The role of India as a global leader is extremely important, especially for the involvement of a wider circle of countries," Sybia said.

"Prime Minister Modi said in the presence of Putin it is time to end the endless war. We support this position. Ukraine is willing to end the war, we have realistic proposals and it is time to move towards diplomatic efforts," he said, without going into details.

Sybia said he briefed Jaishankar on Russia's attacks on civilian ships, ports and infrastructure. "Because of Russian aggression, the Black Sea has become a battlefield. Among the

victims, unfortunately, are citizens of India. We express our deepest condolences to their families and the people of India," he said.

The two sides discussed ways to ensure freedom of navigation in the Black Sea, with Sybia saying the issue extends beyond Ukraine as Russia's blocking of vital routes for the delivery of Ukrainian grains is threatening hunger among millions across the world.

Jaishankar said on social media that approaches to end the conflict and deepen bilateral cooperation also figured in his meeting with President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

Zelenskyy, in a social media post, said Ukraine is "grateful to India for its commitment to ending this unjust war".

"This certainly must not be a time of war. Peace is needed. This is India's clear position," Zelenskyy said.

"We hope that other major world powers will also take a clear stance that this war must end and that a reliable peace must be achieved."

In the context of bilateral ties, Jaishankar and Sybia discussed cooperation in education, health,

agriculture, digitalisation, innovation, diplomatic training and development cooperation. Jaishankar said trade, which spans sectors ranging from pharmaceuticals, food and agriculture to machinery and chemicals, has seen disruption due to the war and logistical challenges.

"At the same time, there has been a visible resilience and some new possibilities have emerged," Jaishankar said. Sybia added that two-way trade is valued at \$2.6 billion, having significant potential for growth.

Jaishankar responded to a question about the impact of proposed US sanctions on India's purchases of Russian oil by saying that the conflict in Ukraine can only be resolved through negotiations. He pointed to the evidence of providing energy to India's civilian people at a time when the world energy situation is very difficult.

"This is something where clearly our side has the perspective, which we respect, and we have ours, which I would expect others to also respect," Jaishankar said. This contradicted Jaishankar's earlier statement that somebody is buying or not buying oil, aluminium, minerals, metals or fertilisers. This conflict will be solved by dialogue, diplomacy (and negotiation), and that is why it is something we would encourage."

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NEW DELHI: Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla on Thursday constituted a 31-member joint committee of Parliament (JPC) to review the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, more than three weeks after the proposal to send the controversial legislation to a parliamentary panel was accepted in the Lower House.

A Lok Sabha bulletin added that Bharatiya Janata Party lawmaker Sanjay Jaishwal, a four-term MP from Bihar, is the chairperson of the panel. The panel has 14 BJP members, including Jaishwal and a total of 19 National Democratic Alliance lawmakers. The Telugu Desam Party, Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party have one member each, and the Janata Dal (United) has two members. Three nominated members who had joined the BJP - C Sadanandhan, Master, former external affairs secretary Harsh Vardhan Shringla, and criminal lawyer Ujjwal Deoghar Nikam - are part of the panel.

The Congress has five berths. The Samajwadi Party, Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) and Indian Union Muslim League have one member each. The Trinamool Congress - both of them loyal to Mamata Banerjee - and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) have two members each in the panel. No member of the rebel TMC group found a place.

THE AMENDMENTS ESTABLISH A DESIGNATED AUTHORITY TO OVERSEE VESTING, MANAGEMENT AND DISPOSAL OF FOREIGN FUNDS AND ASSETS

Jaishwal thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Birla. "Heartfelt thanks for this important responsibility," he said. This will be the 19th joint committee formed on controversial bills since 2014 and the ninth since 2024.

On August 12, the Lok Sabha referred the FCRA amendment bill to a JPC for an extensive review after multiple stakeholders, including church bodies, objected to the legislation's provisions that allowed a Centre-appointed authority to take over assets donated through foreign donations if the organisation failed to retain its FCRA licence.

First introduced in the budget session of 2024, the bill, the first triggered major controversy with the Opposition, several church delegations and three CMs of Christian-majority states opposed it.

The amendments establish a designated authority for "a comprehensive framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contribution and assets, including provisional and permanent

vesting." A provision stated that the government can appoint a "designated authority" to take over, manage, or sell assets created from foreign funds by a non-governmental organisation (NGO) whose licence under FCRA was cancelled, suspended, or simply not renewed. The bill plans to do away with section 15 of the current act that limits the scope of the authority to manage the activities of the organisation, utilise foreign contribution or dispose of the assets created out of it, in case adequate funds are not available for running such an activity.

The panel has 21 members from the Lok Sabha and 10 from the Upper House.

Along with Jaishwal, Bhartruhari Mahtab, Tejasi Surya, Kamlesh Jangle, Mulesh Kumar Chandraakant Dalal, Nishikant Dubey, Vishnu Dayal Ram, Ananta Nayak and Arvind Dharmapuri belong to the BJP from the Lok Sabha. C Sadanandhan, Master, Harsh Vardhan Shringla, Ujjwal Deoghar Nikam, Sat Paul Sharma and Akula Gurjar are members of the ruling party from the Rajya Sabha.

The Congress lawmakers include Anto Antony, Captain Virat Fernandes, Md Humayun Kabir, Md Ghousia Akter and Christopher Manickam. Zia Ur Rehman of the SP, TMC's Kalyan Banerjee and Senaka Gurusamy, JD(U)'s Kausalya Kumari and Sanjay Jha, and DMK's A Raja and P Wilson are also part of the panel.

Rajnath unveils 10-yr roadmap to bolster global defence ties

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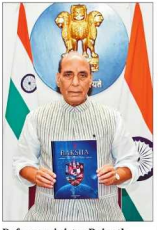
NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday released Raksha, a 10-year strategic roadmap for India's defence diplomacy, outlining the country's vision for strengthening global partnerships, the defence ministry said.

The Raksha defence diplomacy document marks a shift in India's strategic engagement, aligning national security objectives with proactive global cooperation, fostering long-term stability and mutual growth," the defence ministry said in a statement.

This comes when boosting defence exports is a key government priority. India recently reorganised its defence attaché network abroad to drive military exports, focusing on countries likely to buy weapons and systems from India rather than those selling it to military hardware.

The key pillars highlighted in the Raksha blueprint include strategic partnerships, capacity building, exports and manufacturing, and promoting Make-in-India defence products to establish the country as a reliable global defence manufacturing hub. India has aimed for \$50,000 crore in defence exports by 2029-30. The country's defence exports hit a record \$38,424 crore in 2025-26, up 63% from \$23,622 crore in the previous financial year.

The hardware exported includes missiles, artillery guns, rockets, armoured vehicles, offshore patrol vessels, personal protective gear, radars, surveillance systems, ammunition, components and systems/sub-systems. Several policy reforms have



Defence minister Rajnath Singh releases the 'RAKSHA' document in New Delhi on Thursday.

been ushered in by the government in the past few years to boost the Indian defence industry, including simplification of the industrial licensing procedure, removal of patents and components from the license regime and simplification of export authorisation.

Defence public sector undertakings (DPSUs) accounted for 54.84% of defence exports in 2025-26, while the private sector contributed the remaining 45.16%. Official data shows that DPSU exports jumped 15% over the previous year, while private firms recorded a 14% increase. The private sector's share rose to \$17,353 crore worth of defence exports, while DPSUs contributed \$21,071 crore. Their respective figures in the previous financial year stood at \$15,243 crore and \$8,380 crore.

"As defence diplomacy is a core pillar of India's foreign policy, this document provides a clear, actionable vision for the next decade, ensuring that India remains an anchor of peace, stability, and a rule-based order in an evolving global landscape," the defence ministry added.

{ SAYS RAM TEMPLE TRUST'S NEW CEO }

'Will take 3-4 days to understand role'

Pawan Dixit

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LUCKNOW: Ar Marshall (ret'd) Jeetendra Mishra, appointed the first chief executive officer (CEO) of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, arrived in Ayodhya on Thursday morning and said he would take another three to four days to understand his responsibilities before formally taking charge.

Though appointed CEO, Mishra has not formally taken charge of the post yet, people familiar with the matter said. Mishra held closed-door meetings with trust office-bearers during his first day, understanding its finances, staffing and security protocols.

"Over the next two, three, four, or five days, as the Trust desires, I will sit with them and thoroughly understand my role. Once I have understood it, I will take over as the CEO," he told reporters after his first meeting with trust members.

"I consider myself extremely fortunate to have been given this responsibility twice in my life—once in service of the nation, and now in service of Ram temple, devotees, and the administration of the temple. My heart is filled



Ram Temple trust's first CEO Ar Marshall (ret'd) Jeetendra Mishra in Ayodhya on Thursday.

with gratitude," Mishra said.

Mishra, 62, who headed the Western Air Command during Operation Sindoor, arrived from New Delhi around 9.15 am and was received by trust general secretary Gohind Dev Giri and treasurer Mahesh Bhagchandia. He also visited the Ram temple and offered prayers.

"Today, I attended the first meeting of the Trust, which was an introductory meeting where we got to know about each

other's work," Mishra said. Giri said the standard operating procedures specifying his duties and responsibilities would be prepared in the coming days.

"Trust members will meet on Friday and request the CEO to take charge at the earliest," he added. Mishra later attended a meeting on the trust's accounts in the evening, where he was briefed on its administrative and financial arrangements.

The members of the trust said Mishra was briefed in detail by the trustees about the alleged donation theft case, including the developments that followed the controversy.

The CEO's responsibilities are expected to include temple administration, financial oversight, human resource management, crowd and queue management, infrastructure and coordination with police and other government agencies. One of the CEO's principal responsibilities will be supervising the workforce deployed for the temple's security, cleanliness, maintenance and management.

The number of employees involved in these operations is expected to be around 1,500-2,000.

CONG QUESTIONS APPOINTMENT, TRIGGERING ROW

NEW DELHI: Senior Congress leader Rashid Ali's comments over the appointment of Ar Marshall (ret'd) Jeetendra Mishra as the CEO of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, triggered a row with the BJP and the Congress party's internal factions. The opposition party's "dimag Naxal" mindset of insulting the army and the Ayodhya temple.

Ali reportedly questioned if there was some truth hidden in Operation Sindoor because Mishra was made the CEO of the trust, which had recently been the subject of a major theft controversy. Mishra had headed the Air Force's Western Air Command during Operation Sindoor.

Commenting at a press conference after Ali's comments, BJP spokesperson and Rajya Sabha lawmaker Sudhanshu Trivedi said: "It has now been established that insulting the army and the Ayodhya temple is the Naxal mindset of the Congress. These are the same people who used to call Lord Ram imaginary, deny the existence of Ayodhya and insult Ayodhya." **HTC**

T'gana minister sacked over daughter's remark

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HYDERABAD: Telangana chief minister A Revanth Reddy on Thursday sacked state education and forests minister Konda Surekha from his cabinet, after the All-India Congress Committee (AICC) gave a no-take action against her on disciplinary grounds, even as Surekha responded sharply to her removal saying that the Congress high command acted unilaterally without seeking her explanation.

Surekha was served a show-cause notice on August 20 by the disciplinary committee of the Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee, seeking an explanation for her daughter Konda Sucharitha's remarks during a party in general and the chief minister in particular at a meeting in Warangal on August 19.

Surekha replied to the notice on Sunday, but the Congress party's explanation to the AICC remained unsatisfactory. On Wednesday, Revanth



Reddy, PCC chief Mahesh Kumar Goud and other state Congress leaders held discussions with the top brass. On Wednesday, Surekha met party chief Mallikarjun Kharge in Delhi, however, a day later she claimed she was not given the audience. On Thursday, the AICC gave its nod to sack her from the state cabinet, a PCC leader said.

"In the last couple of years, the Congress has been questioning why she was being held responsible for remarks made by her daughter, whom she described as an independent woman. I am not worried about my dismissal from the cabinet, but what hurt me was the way it was done, without even seeking my explanation," Surekha told reporters.

CONGRESS SEVERES TIES WITH ASSAM ALLY RAJOUR DAL

GUWAHATI: Congress on Thursday severed ties with Rajour Dal, its regional partner in Assam, accusing it of "breaching alliance ethics". This comes five months after the assembly polls and ahead of bye-election to the Nagaon Lok Sabha seat which is expected to be held in the next two months.

The Rajour Dal leadership continuously engaged in malicious propaganda and character assassination against the Congress party, mentioned a release by the Congress state unit. "It is no longer viable to sustain ties with Rajour Dal," it added. Rajour Dal also accused the Congress of failing to be a responsible Opposition party and target BJP over its policies. **HTC**

Andhra ACB arrests TTD dy executive officer in DA case

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HYDERABAD: The Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) of Andhra Pradesh Police on Thursday arrested Mendu Lokanatham, deputy executive officer of Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), that administrator Lord Venkateswara temple on Tirumala hills, in a disproportionate assets case following searches at his residence, office and the houses of his relatives, officials aware of the matter said.

ACB deputy superintendent of police (DST) in Tirupati Maddi Srinivasa Rao said the searches began on Wednesday morning and went on till evening. "Loka-

natham had amassed massive assets disproportionate to his known sources of income," Rao said. After completing the searches, the ACB officials took Lokanatham into custody on Thursday morning and shifted him to the ACB office. "He was produced before the ACB court in Nellore for judicial remand," the DSP said.

The ACB also conducted searches at the residences of the accused officer's brothers-in-law. It also found a property document valued at ₹31.98 lakh, jointly held in the name of the accused officer's wife and others. According to Rao, the case was registered after the Central Bureau of Investigation began

investigating the alleged adulteration of ghee used in the making of Tirumala Laddu prasadam.

According to the ACB official, the CB had completed its investigation into the ghee adulteration case and filed a charge sheet. During the course of the investigation, the CB reportedly came across information relating to the assets of some TTD employees and shared the details with the ACB for further action.

As part of the follow-up action, the ACB's Visakhapatnam office had registered a disproportionate assets case against Kadurupeta Chinna Appanna, who served as personal assistant to the then TTD Chairman V Subba Reddy on April 22, 2026.

MAYAWATI AGAIN REMOVES NEPHEW FROM BSP POST

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LUCKNOW: Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati on Thursday removed her nephew, Akash Anand, as the party's chief national coordinator for the third time since 2004, months after she reinstated him in March following his removal from other key posts and expulsion.

Mayawati said Akash Anand, 31, requires more maturity and trustworthiness with major party responsibilities at this stage. "Time is needed to ensure the party is not harmed in elections by opponents employing all means—conciliation, bribery, force, and division to undermine it," she said at a BSP meeting in Lucknow, where she introduced her younger nephew, Ishan Anand, to the party leaders.

Akash Anand's fresh removal came days after the BSP launched the 2027 Uttar Pradesh assembly election campaign with his two rallies in Hathras and Gautam Buddha Nagar on August 10 and 25. Mayawati has groomed him as her political successor since 2017. She first appointed him as the national coordinator in June 2019. In December 2023, she named Akash Anand as her political heir. Mayawati backtracked on her political heir statement in May 2024. People aware of the matter said a family feud and infighting in the party led to Akash Anand's fresh removal.

ED seizes ₹1 cr in cash, freezes 8 bank accounts in toll fraud case

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LUCKNOW: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has seized approximately ₹1.03 crore in cash and frozen eight bank accounts during searches at 14 premises across five states, Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Haryana and Capital Region (NCR) as part of the agency's money-laundering investigation into alleged fraud involving toll collection at National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) toll plazas, senior ED officials said on Thursday.

The ED's Allahabad sub-zone led by Prayagraj launched searches across Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, J&K, Madhya Pradesh, NCR and West Bengal on Wednesday under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002. The case stems from an FIR registered in January 2025 at Lalgaon police station in Mirzapur. The case involved alleged fraudulent toll collection at the Atralla Toll Plaza and several other toll plazas across the country.

ED officials said they recovered and seized a large volume of incriminating material, including books of account, financial records, bank-related documents and digital devices. The agency said the material is likely to provide further leads into the flow of funds generated through the alleged illegal toll collection mechanism. Investigators have specifically

30 premises in South raided as part of drug money trail probe

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NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate on Thursday carried out coordinated searches at 30 locations across Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh as part of money laundering probes into multiple drug trafficking networks, including those with cross-border links, officials aware of the matter said.

The searches, conducted under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), were based on nine cases registered by state police and the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) since 2022. The action is part of the 'Operation Naxal' (Drug-Free India) campaign and focuses on tracing and disrupting the financial networks behind

drug trafficking, they said. The cases involve trafficking of methamphetamine, hashish oil, ganja and ganja, with links to Sri Lanka and some West Asian countries, involving more than two dozen Indian and foreign nationals.

An official, requesting anonymity, said, "In alignment with the government's policy priority to curb the drug menace, we have accorded high priority to narcotics-related investigations, adopting a targeted financial disruption strategy to dismantle drug networks by tracing illicit proceeds and breaking their financial backbone."

"In the last couple of years, we have seen drug trafficking proceeds laundered through real estate, tradefraud laundering, and crypto assets," he added.

recovered material relating to toll-wise collection and reporting, FASTag collections, bank accounts and financial transactions, suspicious communications and the operation and deployment of unauthorised software applications. The ED probe has also brought under

scrutiny the alleged use of unauthorised mobile applications—'Mobdata' and 'Any'—to facilitate toll collection from vehicles without FASTag or with insufficient FASTag balance and generate fake toll receipts to conceal the collections from NHAI's official system.

BCI has no power to discipline law students: SC on NALSAR episode

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday delivered another rap on the knuckles to the Bar Council of India (BCI), making it clear that the lawyers' regulatory body has no statutory power or business to discipline students pursuing legal education, and cannot dictate to law universities how they should deal with student conduct.

Quashing the BCI's communications directing action against students of the 2026 graduating batch of NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, a bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant said that disciplinary control over law students rests exclusively with the university or educational institution where they are enrolled.

The bench, also comprising justices Joymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana, held that the Advocates Act, 1961, under which the BCI is constituted, did not confer on it either an express or implied power to take disciplinary action against students. While the Council can proscribe and enforce standards of legal education in accordance with law and applicable regulations, "it cannot, however, take disciplinary action against a law student."

Declaring the BCI's communication of August 13 and all subsequent modified communications against the NALSAR students to

SC tells lawyers injured during protest against BCI to move HC

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday directed lawyers allegedly assaulted during protests against Bar Council of India (BCI) chairman Manan Mishra to approach the Delhi High Court with a plea seeking a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe and immediate preservation of CCTV footage of the August 20-21 incidents.

A bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana said the high court was the appropriate

forum as the alleged assaults took place at the BCI office in New Delhi.

"It should not appear as if everything must come to this court and that we have an institutional bias. You can approach the Delhi high court," the bench told advocate Prashant Bhushan, who mentioned the matter for urgent listing.

The bench questioned why the protesting lawyers had not used the legal mechanisms to raise their grievances, while acknowledging their right to protest. **HTC**

Parameshwar questioned the authority under which the Council had directed a university to conduct an investigation into representations made by its students.

The bench agreed, "As far as the conduct of law students is concerned, the Bar Council of India has neither jurisdiction nor statutory competence. That falls exclusively within the domain of the educational institution or university. There cannot be any dispute about that," the court said.

Appearing for the BCI, its chairman and senior advocate Manan Kumar Mishra did not seek to defend the withdrawn communications on merits, but said the Council had already closed the matter. "The Council, in its meeting, has said that there is nothing further and that everything has been resolved," Mishra said.

The bench, however, made it clear that withdrawal of the communications did not answer the larger question of jurisdiction. The BCI comes into the picture when a student graduates and seeks enrolment as an advocate. At that stage, it can examine whether the statutory conditions for enrolment have been met. But whether a student should be allowed to continue pursuing legal education is a matter for the university, it added.

"If a law student commits an act involving moral turpitude" and the university nevertheless allows the

student to complete the course, the BCI can examine the issue when the student subsequently seeks enrolment, the bench explained.

The ruling assumes significance coming a day after the Supreme Court subjected the functioning of the BCI to a tighter oversight mechanism, directing that the Attorney General for India and Solicitor General be "actively associated" with every policy decision of the Council until it is reconstituted through fresh elections.

The latest ruling adds a judicial finding of lack of jurisdiction to the court's earlier criticism of the BCI's handling of the NALSAR episode.

The controversy began after a section of NALSAR students objected to CJI Kant being invited as chief guest for their convocation. A representation was submitted on July 23 by 70 members of the outgoing LLB batch, with students from other batches subsequently expressing solidarity. The students had cited remarks made by the CJI during proceedings on a plea concerning alleged police excesses during student protests in Delhi.

On August 14, the same bench had come down heavily on the BCI for intervening in the controversy, saying it had "no business" interfering with the students' right to protest. The BCI subsequently withdrew its directions and Mishra apologised to the students.

306 killed in ethnic violence since May '23: Manipur HM

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IMPHAL: At least 306 people have been killed, and 49 are still missing in the ethnic violence that broke out in May 2023, Manipur home minister Govindas Konthoujam informed the state's legislative assembly on Thursday.

The northeastern state was rocked by ethnic strife that broke out on May 3, 2023 between the numerically dominant Meitei community that mostly inhabit Imphal Valley and tribal Kuki-Zo communities, who live primarily in the hill districts. Violent clashes broke out after a 'Tribal Solidarity March' was organised in the hill districts to protest against the Meitei community's demand for Scheduled Tribes (ST) status.

"Since the violence started on May 3, 2023, 306 people have died, and 49 people are still missing as of August 31, 2023," Konthoujam said, responding to a query by BJP legislator Sapam Ranjan Singh.

The ethnic strife — which also saw other communities like Nagas getting involved in the later stages — led to President's rule being imposed in the state on February 13 last year after the BJP-led government headed by Biren Singh resigned on February 9. It was



Manipur home minister Govindas Konthoujam

revoked on February 4 this year, hours before the formation of a new state government with BJP leader Y Khenchhand Singh as the chief minister.

The assembly proceedings also witnessed a war of words between the treasury and opposition benches when Congress legislator Kangjam Ranjit raised the issue of the killing of four Naga civilians in Kangpokpi district in May.

Konthoujam said four suspects had been arrested and that the National Investigation Agency (NIA) was investigating the case.

When asked about allegations that cadres of the Kuki National Front (KNF) and its leader, who is the husband of deputy chief minister Nemcha Kipgen, were involved in the killings, the minister said: "There is no concrete information on whether KNF (P) was involved in the killings or not."

"NIA is a premier agency in the country. We also pursue the case with them from time to time. We will try to ensure that justice is delivered," he added. Responding to the home minister, the Congress MLA said, "Please, work hard," and added, "Let's hand over the government to NIA."

Chief minister Y Khenchhand Singh intervened, saying allegations made in public and findings of a probe were two different matters. "There was pressure that the village chief of Leiton Vaiphei be arrested for his alleged involvement in the killing. However, when NIA investigated the case, it was learnt that the village chief was in Guwahati for medical treatment for more than a week before the incident happened," he said.

Kuki MLA Kimmo Haokip Hanchang on Thursday urged the state government to ensure the supply of food, medicines and fuel to every part of the state.

The Kuki People's Alliance MLA, along with Independent MLA, Haokholet Kipgen, on Wednesday became the first Kuki legislators to attend a session of the Manipur Assembly in person since ethnic violence broke out in the state in May 2023.

(With agency inputs)

Centre invites Ladakh leaders for talks in national Capital on Sept 9

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SRINAGAR: The Centre has invited Ladakh bodies for a fresh round of talks in New Delhi on September 9, a day ahead of a march announced by the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) from Kargil to Leh to press for statehood, Sixth Schedule status, and other key demands, officials familiar with the matter said.

The ministry of home affairs (MHA) has fixed an official meeting of the sub-committee on 9th September in Delhi. This is part of the ongoing dialogue for deepening democratic processes in Ladakh, chief secretary Ashish Kundra said on X on Thursday.

So far, the representatives of Ladakh bodies have held three rounds of talks with MHA offi-

THE TALKS WILL BE HELD A DAY AHEAD OF A MARCH BY KDA TO PRESS THEIR DEMANDS FOR STATEHOOD AND SIXTH SCHEDULE STATUS

cials. On August 19, regional leaders met MHA officials in Leh and handed over a list of "non-negotiable" demands. A day later, the Ladakh administration dropped cases against 25 people registered over the September 24, 2025, clashes in the Union Territory.

Meanwhile, KDA announced full support for the Kargil-Leh padyatra, scheduled from Sep-

tember 10 to 24. Led by social activist Sandeep Pandey and KDA leader Sajjad Kargili, the march was finalised during a meeting in Kargil also attended by co-chairman Asgar Ali Karbala.

Nod for AHDs in 7 districts Meanwhile, Ladakh lieutenant governor VK Saxena approved a notification from the UT revenue department creating Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDs) across all seven districts.

The decision extends elected local self-governance — previously limited to Leh and Kargil — to five newly created districts: Sham, Nubra, Changthang, Zaskar, and Drass. The decision follows the Centre's July 13 announcement establishing the new councils.

Classroom innovators to be feted on Teachers Day

Sanjay Maurya

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NEW DELHI: For a growing number of university teachers, the classroom is no longer confined to lecture halls. It extends to crime laboratories where students work on live evidence, field projects shaped by local communities and laboratories developing technologies for disasters, weather forecasting and climate change.

This year's National Teachers Awards highlight that shift in higher education, recognising teachers whose work brings teaching, research and real-world problem-solving closer together. The 21

higher-education awardees include academics developing drones for disaster response, designing sustainable public buildings, using artificial intelligence to advance Sanskrit scholarship and working on technologies to tackle climate change.

President Droupadi Murmu will confer the awards on September 5 on 69 teachers — 48 school teachers and 21 teachers and faculty members from higher education institutions and polytechnics — at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will interact with awardee teachers on the eve of Teachers' Day on Friday at his residence, 7, Lok Kail-

PRESIDENT MURMU WILL CONFER AWARDS ON 69 TEACHERS ON SEPTEMBER 5

yan Marg in the capital.

At BITS Pilani, Prof Vinay Chomola works across Internet of Things (IoT), artificial intelligence, drones, cybersecurity and health-care. His focus is on making advanced technology affordable and accessible beyond well-funded laboratories, according to the award citation.

His team is developing auto-

mous drones that can operate where human access is difficult or dangerous, including during disasters. "Education should not stop at technical knowledge; students also need the confidence, judgment and resilience to turn ideas into impact," Chomola told HT.

At IIT Roorkee, Prof Ajitkita Agrawal's work takes education into communities. In a state government school project in Haridwar district, her team involved students, teachers and parents in designing the building, rather than limiting engagement to project funders. "Stakeholder engagement is an essential part of social sustainability," Agrawal said.

At the National Forensic Sciences University in Gandhinagar, Prof Jayrajish Saravali has developed postgraduate courses in forensic pharmacy, food forensics and medical devices. His centre has examined thousands of pharmaceutical, food and agricultural cases, with students working on live evidence, the ministry said.

At IIT Hyderabad, Prof Kirri Chandra Sahu studies raindrops at different altitudes to improve weather forecasting and climate modelling. At Karnataka Sanskrit University, Prof Shivani V is linking Paninian grammar with AI through Samhishtha, a digital platform for Sanskrit scholarship.

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Four armies join rescue efforts in Nepal tunnels

Prawesh Lama
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NEW DELHI: More than a week after a Himalayan glacier collapse sent a wall of water, rock and ice tearing across the Nepal-Tibet border, the search for the workers it swept into mountainside hydro-power project tunnels has become the disaster's most pressing race against time—an underground rescue that has now drawn tunnel specialists from four national armies to a cluster of hydropower sites in Nepal's Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts.

At least 966 workers are missing or trapped across 11 project sites in the two districts, according to company-level records reviewed by HT. The figure, drawn from submissions by the supervisors of the firms operating each site, exceeds the official count. Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRMA) put the number at "around 900" as of 3pm on Thursday, up from 639 on August 30.

Most of those unaccounted for were inside tunnels or underground powerhouses when the flood struck on August 26—the parts of a hydropower project that sit deepest inside the mountain, and offer the fewest routes out when a debris flow arrives.

The concentration of the missing has forced Kathmandu to run what are four parallel tunnel operations, each led by a different combination of armies.

Nepal Army spokesperson Brigadier Raja Ram Basnet told HT that specialists from India, China and South Korea were now working alongside Nepalese troops at the worst-affected sites. "Upper Trishuli 1 is a major project site where most people are reported missing," Brigadier Basnet said. "The tunnel experts from the Korean and Nepalese armies are at one site, while another site has experts from the Chinese and Nepalese army within UTI. Meanwhile Indian army experts are working with the Nepalese army in the Chilime and Langtang Khola project. It is a joint effort to rescue the missing."



Rescue team members work to enter the tunnel at the Upper Trishuli 3A Hydropower Station in Rasuwa on Thursday.

Upper Trishuli 1 project site worst hit

The 216MW Upper Trishuli 1, where companies from Nepal, China and South Korea share the works, accounts for the largest share of the missing. Of the 1,433 people registered as working on the project when the flood arrived, supervisors have reported 576 unaccounted for—including 114 known to have been inside the head tunnel and headworks tunnel at the time. At least nine of the missing are South Korean nationals. Power China, the largest contractor on the project, alone lists 385 of its civil workers as missing. Two further sites on the same river system carry heavy losses of those still trapped in the underground works is not yet clear: At Upper Trishuli 3B, 191 workers are missing; another 23 who had been inside the tunnel escaped on the first day. At Rasuwagadhi, a 111MW project further upstream, 93 are unaccounted for after the flood tore through, though the precise location of those still trapped in the underground works is not yet clear; three climbed to higher ground as the water arrived and four walked out on their own two days later.

Elsewhere on the network, at Langtang Khola, 41 workers were reported missing or trapped at an underground powerhouse and 11 got clear on Day 2; rescuers pulled two bodies from the site on Friday.

At Chilime, 72 people inside the works managed to leave just in time—six others did not, and an Indian Army technical team is now working with Nepalese soldiers to reach them. Indian's ambassador to Nepal, Navin Srivastava, said on X after visiting

the team stationed at Syabrubesi, near Chilime, that the joint effort had already pushed 100 metres inside the tunnel using specialised equipment. Heavy machinery was being brought in, he said, to advance further. The ground was "swamp-like" and the terrain challenging, but both sides were pressing on.

The smaller sites in the cluster together account for another 55 missing: 42 at the underground powerhouse of Upper Trishuli 3A; seven at Malling Khola; four at Rasuwa-Bhotekoshi, from where three Chinese and two Indian workers were airlifted out the second day; three at the Trishuli Hydropower Project, two of them security guards; two at Middle Trishuli Ganga, where one injured worker was rescued on Day 2 and one at Devighat, a security guard.

A Nepal home ministry official, who asked not to be named, said review meetings chaired by home minister Sudan Gurung had been unambiguous—a first find route to the trapped workers, then find a way to send in food and water.

For the teams inside the tunnels, that communication is the immediate goal. Establishing whether workers are alive in the sealed pockets of the underground powerhouses—and, if they are, keeping them supplied while the excavation continues—will shape how long the rescue can plausibly run before it turns into a recovery. The two bodies pulled from Langtang Khola on Friday were the first confirmed recoveries from any of the hydropower sites since the count of the missing began to climb last week.

CENTRE REVIEWS READINESS OF UTs, STATES AGAINST GLACIAL OUTBURST

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NEW DELHI: Union home secretary Govind Mohan on Thursday reviewed the preparedness of Himalayan states and Union Territories against the risks of Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (GLOFs) and snow avalanches. The review meeting comes against the backdrop of recent flash floods in Nepal, which claimed over 1,000 lives with more than 5,000 people still reportedly missing.

During the meeting, Mohan assessed early warning systems, the monitoring of vulnerable glacial lakes and snow-covered regions, identification of high-risk locations, flow path planning, timely dissemination of alerts, evacuation preparedness, and response mechanisms, the ministry of home affairs said in a statement.

The ministry said the states and UTs presented their mitigation strategies, detailing measures for lake monitoring, dam safety, early alert dissemination, community preparedness, and local resource deployment. "Mohan urged states to shift from response-oriented measures toward risk-informed planning, preventive mitigation, and community-level readiness," it said.

"States and UTs were advised to maintain close coordination among state agencies, district administrations and scientific institutions so that warnings are acted upon promptly and effectively," the MHA added in its statement.

The home secretary also directed states to regularly review their preparedness plans, fix gaps in evacuation arrangements, and expedite the implementation of the Central Government's 2024 GLOF mitigation project to minimise loss of life and property across vulnerable Himalayan belts, it said.



PM MODI MEETS WATER RESOURCES MINISTERS FROM BJP RULED STATES

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday held a meeting with water resources ministers from 14 BJP-ruled states amid a renewed push for water conservation, revival of water bodies and improved use of technology in water management as part of the larger Viksit Bharat campaign, people aware of the matter said.

Modi's meeting with the ministers came after he chaired the valedictory session of a two-day national departmental summit on water organised by the Ministry of Jal Shakti. During the session, he called for better time-bound action plans, the need for water conservation, and the need for advanced and coordinated planning to deal with water shortages and called for greater use of treated wastewater for agriculture.

On Wednesday, the ministers interacted with BJP president Narender Modi on Thursday took stock of the flood situation in Uttar Pradesh's Varanasi, followed by a workshop at the party headquarters on Thursday.

According to a BJP leader, privy to the meeting, the workshop reflected coordination between the party and the government on key governance issues. "The ministers shared details of some of their best practices. There was discussion on how to scale initiatives for water conservation, revival of water bodies and using technology and artificial intelligence for improving outcomes," the leader said.

Former lawmaker and senior BJP leader Vinay Sahasrabudhhe, who heads the party's good governance cell, said the two-day Jal Shakti Manthan workshop was attended by 25 ministers from 14 states. "We discussed ways for ensuring effective governance. Other departments and ministries will also conduct further workshops under our Good Governance programme," he said.

Accused stabs sexual assault complainant to death in Niry

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KARNAL: A 24-year-old sexual assault victim was stabbed to death at her residence in Haryana's Yamuna nagar allegedly by the accused in the case, who was out on bail, police said on Thursday.

According to police, the incident took place around 7 pm on Wednesday. The victim, a mother of two children aged four years and nine months, was rushed to the civic hospital by her brother-in-law, where doctors declared her dead, said an officer, quoting the complaint.

According to the complaint, the accused, who is her brother-in-law, had been harassing the woman's residence, and she ran for safety to a neighbour's house. The accused followed her and kept attacking her with

THE WOMAN'S HUSBAND SAID THE ACCUSED, WHO WAS THEIR NEIGHBOUR, HAD BEEN HARASSING THE FAMILY FOR TWO YEARS

a knife while her husband was away for work. The woman sustained grievous injuries on the neck. However, when the woman's brother-in-law arrived, the accused fed her the weapon, it added.

The woman's husband said the accused, who is her brother-in-law, had been harassing the family for two years.

He alleged that the accused had previously sexually assaulted

his wife, following which a case was registered against him. "The victim was assaulted together with me and we lodged another case against him, but now my wife has been murdered," the woman's husband said.

Station House Officer (SHO), Jagdhari city police station, inspector Vinod Kumar said a case was previously registered against the accused under Section 74 (assault or the use of criminal force against a woman with the intent to outrage her modesty) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

He was jailed but later released on bail.

"Later, he had a fight with the victim's husband after which he was jailed again, but secured bail from the Punjab and Haryana High Court. Several teams have been formed to apprehend him immediately," he said.

5 dead in UP rain-related incidents, Ganga swells up; PM Modi takes stock

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NEW DELHI/VARANASI/PATNA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday took stock of the flood situation in Uttar Pradesh's Varanasi, followed by a workshop at the party headquarters on Thursday.

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A temple submerged near Ganga river in Varanasi.

about 2am on Thursday, killing a man and his two children and injuring his wife and another daughter, DM Pulkit Garg said. In Anethi, Shyamli Chauhan (65) died after a mud wall collapsed amid heavy rain in Naya Purva village on Wednesday evening, police said. In Barabanki, Shakti Kumar Singh (62) died and his son-in-law got injured after a mud wall collapsed on them after heavy rain on Wednesday night.

In Bihar, the rising Ganga prompted authorities to step up vigilance, with the river expected to breach its "highest flood mark" at Patna's Gandhi Ghat on Thursday night, the Disaster Management Department said. The Ganga and Varuna rivers are swelling, with water currently rising at the rate of 2cm per hour.

STALIN'S PLEA AGAINST TVK MLA'S KOLATHUR WIN DISMISSED

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CHENNAI: The Madras high court on Thursday dismissed a writ petition filed by DMK president and former Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin seeking a "100% control" over the Kolathur assembly constituency and, consequently, a declaration that he was the duly elected candidate after nullifying the election of TVK MLA VS Bhat.

A bench of chief justice SA Dharmadhikari and justice G Arul Murugan held that Stalin's writ petition was not maintainable since the rights sought by him amounted, in substance, to a "challenge to the election of the returned candidate".

The court said, "The high court also rejected the 'attempt to frame the dispute as one concerning only the post-result verification of EVMS and VVPAT units'".



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[ARRESTED ON AUG 29]

KPSC exam row: IAS Gangwar suspended

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government has suspended IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar after his arrest in a corruption case related to the recruitment conducted by the Karnataka Public Service Commission, with officials claiming that he played a key role in manipulating the process.

The suspension follows investigations by the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) and the Directorate of Enforcement. He was arrested on August 29.

However, officials aware of the matter said Gangwar will receive a subsistence allowance under Rule 4 of the All India Service (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1969, during his suspension.

Meanwhile, the CID investigation has found that Gangwar allegedly

had access to the questions before the examination and later interfered with candidates OMR sheets. "Candidates who had paid advance amounts were allegedly given an advantage at both stages, with Gyanendra changing their OMR responses and later ensuring they received higher marks in the interviews and were selected," an official said.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar has alleged that Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and NDA leaders were connected to the KPSC irregularities and said information gathered by the Home Department would be disclosed. "Information has been received about the connection of BJP leaders in the KPSC irregularities. The information with the home minister against NDA leaders will be disclosed soon," Shivakumar said.

2 soldiers missing in Yamuna found dead

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KARNAL: The bodies of two soldiers who went missing after being swept away during a training exercise at the Hathnikund Barrage in Haryana's Yamuna nagar district were recovered, police said on Thursday.

The body of the first missing soldier was recovered along the Yamuna river bank near Bartha village in Uttar Pradesh's Saharanpur district, 14km downstream from the barrage.

He was identified as Ajay Kumar from Akhnoor, Jammu and Kashmir, according to police officers aware of the matter.

Divers and residents retrieved the second body nearly 200km downstream near a local market in Jind city, Haryana, said Ramkishan Kumar, a retired captain of Para SF residing in Jind. He

identified the deceased as Aryan Patel from Maharashtra, who was participating in special forces training at the barrage.

The Indian Army has not yet officially confirmed either recovery or the identities of the deceased.

A statement from the defence public relations officer (PRO) was awaited. The incident occurred around 6 pm on Tuesday when a boat carrying five army personnel moving downstream near the barrage got caught in a powerful current and capsized. While three soldiers swam to safety, the other two were swept away.

A multi-agency search and rescue operation, including the army, Indian Air Force, NDRF, SDRF units from Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, local police and civil authorities, was launched following the incident.

Amid Raj HC acting CJ issue, SC collegium picks his junior as J&K HC chief justice

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NEW DELHI: Even as Rajasthan high court acting chief justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma has publicly rejected allegations of "corruption," "nepotism" and "misuse of administrative powers" levelled against him by Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta, calling them the product of "animosity," the Supreme Court collegium has chosen a judge junior to him for elevation as chief justice of another high court—a decision that assumes significance as Justice Sharma is just 23 days away from retirement.

The collegium on August 31 recommended Rajasthan High Court judge Justice Puspendra Singh Bhati as the chief justice of the Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh high court, while separately recommending Chhattisgarh high court judge Justice Sanjay Kumar Agrawal as the next chief justice of Rajasthan.

The recommendations came even as the institutional process on the allegations against justice

Sharma is still underway and the Chief Justice of India, Surya Kant, has made clear that the allegations cannot be treated as findings against him.

The significance of Justice Bhati's elevation lies partly in the seniority equation. Justice Sharma and Justice Bhati were appointed additional judges of the Rajasthan high court on the same day—November 16, 2016, but Justice Sharma was placed ahead of Bhati in the original order of seniority.

Both were subsequently made permanent judges with effect from March 16, 2018.

Justice Sharma, born in September 1964, is due to retire on September 26, leaving him with barely three weeks in office. Jus-

tice Bhati, born in September 1970, has more than six years remaining on the bench and is due to retire in September 2032.

Thus, while the collegium's recommendation of Bhati as chief justice of the Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh High Court is not, by itself, a finding on any of the allegations against Justice Sharma, it has the effect of passing over a senior judge who had been ahead of Justice Bhati in the Rajasthan High Court's seniority list and was serving as its acting chief justice.

The development comes days after Justice Mehta wrote three letters to CJ Kant—on August 2, 10 and 17, urging that a regular chief justice from another high court be appointed to Rajasthan, and that Justice Sharma be transferred out of the state.

Justice Mehta had accused Justice Sharma of "corruption," "nepotism" and "favouritism," besides alleging that he misused his powers as master of the roster by selectively shifting cases to his own bench and favouring "right and influential litigants." He also questioned a series of administra-

tive decisions concerning the high court's judicial principles and designation of senior advocates and a three-day election in Jaipur.

Justice Sharma, in his first post-retirement public statement, has now rejected the allegations as "unfounded, false and factless," saying he has submitted his response along with evidence to the CJ.

"Recent developments in the media and social media" prompted him to issue the statement, Justice Sharma said, adding that the allegations had been made out of "animosity".

He appealed to the media, lawyers and others to wait for the court's decision and said he would present his side publicly at the appropriate time, subject to the CJ's approval.

The response comes against the backdrop of CJ Kant's categorical assertion last week that the matter was being examined through the appropriate institutional mechanism and that he would give a fair and equitable opportunity to respond.

CONG BRASS YET TO DECIDE ON WOMAN MLA FOR K'TAKA CABINET BERTH

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NEW DELHI: Top Congress leaders have held a couple of meetings this week to identify a woman legislator from Karnataka to be inducted into the state cabinet, an issue they had not been able to resolve for the past few months, people aware of the matter said on Thursday. There are four women Congress legislators in the Karnataka assembly.

"The party had identified Kaneez Fatima, a two-term legislator, but she has language issues that makes her unsuitable for a ministerial job," said a senior leader, requesting anonymity.

Another possible candidate was Roopkala but senior leaders have argued that her father, KH Muniyappa is a senior cabinet minister, and that two leaders from the same family should not be given ministerial berths. "There are 23 women lawmakers who can be given ministerial responsibilities but the appointment has to justify the regional balance in the cabinet," the leader cited above said, referring to challenges in making the choice.

The previous Congress government led by Siddaramaiah had one woman minister—Laxmi Hebbalkar. But she was not included in the DK Shivakumar's preferred list for the cabinet when he became the chief minister in June this year. "We are aware it is an embarrassing situation that our government does not have a single woman in the cabinet. But we are trying to find a suitable face keeping in mind various factors such as seniority and regional and caste balance," the leader added.

Pilot falls ill, IndiGo flight makes mayday call, diverted to Oman

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NEW DELHI: A Mayday call signalling a life-threatening emergency was made after one of the pilots of a Doha-Bengaluru IndiGo flight became incapacitated, prompting its diversion to Oman's Muscat on Thursday. Officials said the pilot required urgent medical attention and that flight 6E 1302 landed safely in Muscat, where a medical team attended to the affected crew member.

"The pilot became incapacitated during the flight, and a Mayday emergency was declared," an official said. It was not immediately clear whether the Airbus A320neo aircraft's first officer (co-pilot) or the pilot-in-command needed medical attention.

In a statement, IndiGo said the crew member is feeling better now. It added that an alternate aircraft and a new crew were arranged for the flight from Muscat to Bengaluru. The passengers were being provided refreshments and regular updates in Muscat, it said.

"We regret the inconvenience caused to our customers and are making all efforts to minimise it," the statement said. The incident came two days after a Goa-Delhi IndiGo flight made an emergency landing shortly after take-off. A person aware of the matter said the issue was related to one of the engines, even as IndiGo has not confirmed it.

It was the second IndiGo flight to face an engine snag in

AI EXPRESS FLIGHT REPORTS SNAG, LANDS AT LUCKNOW AIRPORT

LUCKNOW: An Air India Express flight from Varanasi to Delhi made a precautionary landing at Chaudhary Charan Singh International Airport in Lucknow on Thursday morning after a smoke detection alarm allegedly went off in its aft cargo compartment, prompting an emergency response.

All 155 passengers and crew members were safely evacuated, while preliminary checks found no smoke or fire, airport officials said.

Flight IX 1253 took off from Varanasi around 8am and landed in Lucknow at 8.52am.

An Air India Express spokesperson said the crew, prioritising passenger safety, opted for a precautionary diversion to Lucknow after detecting a technical issue.

On August 11, a Kolkata-Chennai flight made a priority landing after declaring an emergency when its left engine developed problems on approach.

HT on Wednesday reported that "serious findings" were reported as the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) conducted safety audits of four major airlines ahead of a US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) assessment of India's civil aviation regulator oversight scheduled between November 16 and 20.

The DGCA completed the safety audits in August, three months before a five-member FAA team will visit India.

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EL NINO FORECAST

(SSTs) across the central-eastern equatorial Pacific—the region at the heart of El Niño—are already well above average and continuing to rise. The widely used Niño 3.4 index, which measures SST anomalies in that stretch of ocean, has strengthened from an average of +1.5°C above normal during May-July 2026 and +2°C in July to between +2.2°C and +2.6°C in late July to mid-August, indicating continued intensification.

The temperature deviation beneath the surface is worse. Sea surface ocean temperatures in some areas were more than 8°C above average during July and early August. Together, the surface and subsurface conditions provide “strong support for continued El Niño conditions and the potential for further strengthening” over the coming months.

Experts said a strong El Niño is a serious concern for India. “It can alter rainfall distribution and raise temperatures. Its immediate impact on the withdrawing southwest monsoon may be limited, but it could influence the northeast monsoon and increase the possibility of a warmer-than-normal winter,” said Mahesh Palawat, vice-president at Skymet. “If El Niño persists into early 2027, India may face an enhanced risk of an unusually warm pre-monsoon season and heatwaves. However, El Niño alone does not determine India’s weather; the Indian Ocean Dipole, snow cover, local sea temperatures and other atmospheric factors will also shape the eventual impact.”

Anjal Prakash, an IPCC author and professor of public policy at FLAME University, called WMO’s warning a red flag for India. “With August already 16% rain-deficient and September forecast below-normal, the event threatens kharif yields, water security and rural incomes, while pushing temperatures to record highs. For policymakers, this is also a macro-economic and food-security risk. We need immediate drought-proofing in vulnerable districts, flexible crop advisories, and pre-positioned relief,” he said.

For September to November 2026, WMO’s multi-model forecasts point to an increased likelihood of above-normal temperatures across almost all land areas, alongside rainfall patterns showing what the agency described as “a pronounced and classic anthropic response” to the strong

Pacific El Niño.

A positive phase of the Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) is also expected to develop, reaching a September-October-November seasonal mean value of 0.9°C. The equatorial Atlantic basin is forecast to remain generally warm, with SSTs in both the North and South Tropical Atlantic staying above normal. These conditions, the update noted, may reinforce, weaken or alter typical El Niño impacts in different regions.

UN Secretary-General António Guterres said El Niño was “being supersized before our eyes”. He added: “The science leaves no room for doubt: the planet is in uncharted waters, and those waters are heating up. Sea surface temperatures are rising, temperatures keep climbing, and the world is in the danger zone of extreme weather. The race now is between rising risks and our commitment to take climate action and protect people. We must win this race.”

WMO Secretary-General Celeste Saulo said the event demanded “exceptional preparation and response”. “Never before in the 50-year history of the World Meteorological Organization have we launched such a major mobilisation with National Meteorological and Hydrological Services who are on the frontline of delivering the forecasts and services to save lives and livelihoods,” she said, adding that WMO was working with UN and humanitarian partners to provide climate intelligence for agriculture, health, energy and water resources.

El Niño is a natural climate phenomenon—a warming of ocean surface temperatures in the central and eastern equatorial Pacific that typically occurs every two to seven years and lasts nine to twelve months, with peak intensity between November and February. WMO underlined that the phenomenon itself is not caused by climate change, even as its impacts play out on a warming planet.

The warning comes days after a glacial collapse and flash flood in Nepal left 127 people dead and thousands missing, underscoring the fragility of mountain systems in a warming climate. A day earlier, on Wednesday, the UN Environment Programme (UNEP) said global temperature rise is likely to end the 1.5°C threshold by the close of this decade, pushing climate risks—including intensified extreme weather—to increasingly dangerous heights.

INDIA-BELGIUM TALKS

Investment Fast-Track Mechanism for Belgian companies, making the India-Belgium Business Forum a regular mechanism and strengthening coordination among the financial, fintech and regulatory institutions of both countries, India and Belgium have set a target of doubling bilateral trade over the next five years, Modi said.

Two-way trade is currently worth about \$13 billion, with diamonds accounting for almost 30% of the total figure. “Belgium’s expertise in semi-conductors and India’s scale are complementary to each other. In this direction, we will work together to connect Belgium’s IMEC Institute with India’s semiconductor ecosystem,” Modi said. The two sides will soon conclude a migration and mobility partnership agreement, he said.

De Wever described India as an increasingly important partner in a turbulent world and said Belgium, one of the most internationally connected economies, can serve as India’s gateway to European markets. “We live in a more fragmented and uncertain world, prosperity and security increasingly go hand-in-hand,” he said.

The Letter of Intent on Defence Cooperation finalised by the two sides provides a new framework for everything ranging from military exchanges to research, co-development and co-production of defence hardware. De Wever said, India and Belgium can be partners for the security of economies and supply chains energy security, cyber security and maritime security, even as they address the disruption and weaponisation of supply chains and excessive dependencies, he said.

De Wever spoke more at length on dependencies created by China and the turmoil unleashed by the trade policies of the US administration at a

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

subsequent business event organised by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII).

“These are turbulent times, our world seems ever more divided into great blocs, raising barriers between one another. For them, geopolitics seems like a zero sum game, tariffs can be imposed from one day to the next by anyone on anyone and anything, for reasons that have nothing to do with economics at all,” he said, in an apparent reference to the US.

De Wever also noted that India had warned about dependencies long before Europe experienced a “rude awakening”, its industrial base undermined and over-capacity dumped as low cost goods. “The country that has profited the most from that practice does it well lie far from here, it’s a neighbour you all know,” he said in an obvious reference to China.

Besides the Letter of Intent on Defence Cooperation, a memorandum of understanding (MoU) between the Belgian Security and Defence Industry (BSDI) and Society of Indian Defence Manufacturers (SIDM) will facilitate the co-development and co-production of military equipment. India also announced that it will post a resident defence attaché at its embassy in Brussels.

Another MoU between India’s Central Bureau of Investigation and the Belgium Federal Police will facilitate cooperation in combating trans-national organised crime and cybercrime. This MoU will cover information-sharing and cooperation in tracing fugitives. Two other MoUs will facilitate cooperation in renewable energy and diplomatic training, and the two sides also agreed to establish a consular dialogue.

A defence delegation led by Belgian defence and foreign trade minister Theo Francken, which accompanied De Wever, held separate meetings with representatives of India’s defence industry and concluded eight agreements for the joint production of a wide range of equipment, including transfer of technology.

“India is a major military power in the Indo-Pacific. The country is also strategically located along some of the world’s most important trade routes.”

“For an open trading nation like Belgium, the security of these sea lanes is vital,” Francken said. “China is becoming

increasingly assertive in the Indo-Pacific. Our security does not stop at our borders. That is why we need to work more closely with strong partners such as India.”

An agreement between Belgium’s New Lachausse and India’s Tembo Classic Engineering will see the supply of a production line for two ammunition culibres and tooling for two additional culibres. The installation will have a production capacity of 100 million rounds a year, and the project is worth €50 million. Exal Belgium will supply autonomous toolboxes used to detect, identify and neutralise naval mines for Larsen & Toubro’s project to build mine countermeasure vessels. The first phase covers 12 vessels, though the programme could expand to as many as 59.

Thales Belgium and Kalpani Strategic Systems are tying up to assemble 70mm rockets in India, with Indian suppliers participating in the production process. The first rocket produced entirely in India is expected in early 2027, and Thales is expected to gain an additional order of supply for its international orders.

Belgium’s FN Herstal and Kalpani Strategic Systems are also exploring the establishment of a joint production centre in India to manufacture FN weapons, integrated weapon systems and counter-drone systems.

Flemish drone manufacturer SolOne is working with India’s DGVK Enterprises to introduce its Saboteur drone and its Buzz-kill and Hittchiker interceptors to the Indian market. India’s armed forces have requested information and want to test the systems.

Belgium’s OIP Sensor Systems is cooperating with state-run India Optel Limited on electro-optical systems for the Arjun main battle tank. OIP has supplied more than 130 sights for the Arjun MK I. For Arjun MK II, the company developed a new fire control system that can also launch laser-guided missiles.

Belgium’s John Cockerill Defence is a candidate to supply the turret for the Zorawar, the light tank India is developing for high-altitude operations, while Octave, a specialist in visualisation software, is working with Bharat Electronics. Octave’s technology is already operating in several Indian air defence programmes, including Akash Tiger.

A joint statement issued after

the talks said De Wever conveyed Belgium’s solidarity with India in the fight against terrorism, including cross-border terror. He again condemned the terror attack in Pahalagam in April 2025, and both leaders agreed that the world community must act together against terrorists, including those designated by the UN Security Council, terrorist networks, their safe havens and financing.

Modi and De Wever also discussed recent developments in Ukraine and West Asia. In the context of Ukraine, both sides backed efforts for a comprehensive, just and lasting peace through dialogue and diplomacy, the joint statement said. On West Asia, they discussed developments of concern and emphasised the importance of dialogue and diplomatic engagement to address challenges in a peaceful manner.

De Wever also said he looked forward to welcoming Modi in Brussels in December for the signing of the India-EU free trade agreement.

GLORIA STEINEM DIES

Times interview. Taymor directed the 2010 film “The Glorias,” depicting Steinem’s life across the years and based on her 2015 best-selling autobiography “My Life on the Road.” She was also the subject of a 2018 play, “Gloria: A Life,” and a 2011 HBO documentary “Gloria: In Her Own Words.” Steinem said she considered herself “an entrepreneur of social change.”

“I want to do justice to the women I meet, to tell their stories,” she told The New Yorker magazine in 2015. “It’s making connections, and using myself to listen, because we can’t empower women without listening to their stories.”

Steinem founded the National Women’s Political Caucus in 1971 with former US Representatives Bella Abzug and Shirley Chisholm and writer Betty Friedan, whose 1963 book “The Feminine Mystique” ushered in the second wave of feminism.

Among other groups, she also created the Coalition of Labor Union Women, the Women’s Media Center, Voters for Choice, and the Ms. Foundation for Women. In 2013 then-President Barack Obama awarded her the Presidential Medal of Freedom, the highest US civilian honor.

With her signature long, blonde-streaked, center-parted

hair and aviator glasses, Steinem was the glamorous, hip symbol of the feminist movement, which she emphasized should embrace women of every race.

“If you’ve suffered discrimination, you’re sensitive to it on every level. I learned feminism largely from Black women. Women of colour basically invented feminism,” she told The New Yorker.

Steinem was born on March 25, 1934, in Toledo, Ohio, the younger of two daughters. Her father was a travelling antique dealer. Her parents separated when she was 11, following which Steinem lived with and took care of her mother, who had a mental breakdown and suffered from depression.

The experience impacted Steinem’s views on social justice and marriage, which she believed robbed women of choices and many of their civil rights. “I’d already been a very big child, my mother. I didn’t want to end up as a care of someone else,” she was quoted as saying.

After graduating from Smith College, Steinem began freelancing as a journalist. In 1963, she worked as a Playboy bunny for 11 days for a story for Show magazine. Her two-part groundbreakers expose, “A Bunny’s Tale,” detailed the poor pay and sexist treatment Playboy bunnies—originally waitstaff—endured. But it wasn’t until she attended an abortion speak-out in a New York church the following year that Steinem—who had had a then-illegal abortion in London when she was 22—said her life as a feminist activist really began.

Steinem was often critical of the limitations of marriage. “Women are not going to be equal outside the home until men are equal in it,” she said.

She had no children of her own and it was not until she turned 66 that she decided to wed—to South African businessman and environmentalist David Bale, the father of actor Christian Bale. “I hope this proves what feminists have always said—that feminism is about the ability to choose what’s right at each time of our lives,” she said in a statement about the marriage.

Author Carolyn Heilbrun—who penned 1995 biography “Education of a Woman: The Life of Gloria Steinem”—described her as “the epitome of female beauty and the quintessence of female revolution.”

Kharge demands urgent action in ‘purification’ case

NEW DELHI: Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge has written to Union minister JP Nadra, seeking urgent action against those behind a purification ritual at Ramnalla Maidan in Uttarakhand’s Haldwani after his August 8 public meeting, underlining that the issue is connected to the sentiments of millions who confront this cruel reality every day.

‘Distasteful’: HC on actor’s display of Modi cartoon

KOLKATA: The Calcutta high court on Thursday said that the poster which popular Bengal actor Sreelekha Mitra displayed during a protest rally on July 24, depicting an objectionable cartoon of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, was distasteful and it shocked the conscience of the court. “Why she has done this? This is not merely a cartoon. It is really distasteful. How a prudent citizen can do this? a single bench of Justice Saugata Bhattacharya of the Calcutta high court observed.

‘Unfilled NEET-SS 2025 seats may be returned to TN’

NEW DELHI: The Centre informed the Supreme Court on Thursday that it is willing to return the entire unfilled seats in the NEET Speciality (NEET-SS) 2025 admission process to Tamil Nadu, even as a final decision is likely within this week. Additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhat, representing the Centre, said that some seats which are still unfilled after the second round of counselling are proposed to be reverted back to Tamil Nadu.

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{ OUR TAKE }

Climate models' clarity on calamity

Adaptation has limits, and irreversible losses and permanently changed conditions are certain

The UN Environment Programme said on Wednesday that global temperature rise will, now inevitably, cross 1.5°C within a few years, and that even the most optimistic pathway it modelled peaks at 1.8°C above pre-industrial levels. Most other pathways peak higher. The overshoot can still be held short and then reversed, the report argues, and that possibility needs to be taken seriously to stave off unseen catastrophes.

The report is also candid about what comes now. Adaptation has limits, and irreversible losses and permanently changed conditions are certain. Risks intensify with every additional fraction of a degree and every year spent above the threshold, some impacts accumulate and others arrive abruptly, and the tipping points grow likelier the longer the world stays beyond 1.5°C. Major ice sheets destabilising, the Atlantic circulation disrupted, and a cascade of floods, droughts and other effects that come with it follow.

Last week, a flash flood in the Bhotokoshi river killed more than a thousand people in Nepal and left thousands more missing. Hundreds are feared to have died in China too. Nepal's ministers have since written to a UN Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage, arguing that its losses exceed anything the country can absorb on its own.

The Fund was indeed built for incidents like these. Its founding document lists displacement, relocation and permanent loss among the harms it exists to address although, till now, it has not paid a dollar to any country. Its first funding window drew roughly 180 applications, seeking \$2.8 billion against a paltry \$250 million available, and the first approvals have been put off to December.

Implicit in the mechanism was that disasters would be rare — countries pay into it when they choose to, claims go in during a window of applications and wait their turn. And when governments set it up, they agreed it would create no liability and no right to compensation.

The truth is, nobody has seen what 1.8°C warming looks like. While climate models are clear about what becomes of ice sheets and ocean currents, it is hard to imagine what truly happens to people — just like it was unthinkable to tie the notion of glacial collapses with the scenes seen in Nepal last month. Nepal may not be an exception in a few years' time, and it is time for the reckoning that the climate crisis is here.

Forex boost delivered, over to markets now

The forex swap facility, including an FCNR deposit scheme, launched in June has attracted \$136.4 billion in foreign currency, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Wednesday. What are its larger macroeconomic implications? Three of them can be listed.

The scheme was launched as a one-time foreign currency mobilisation effort in the wake of weak capital flows to India, which could have put pressure on the external account despite a relatively benign current account deficit. The objective has been achieved for now. However, the FCNR deposit scheme is a one-time arrangement that can't be deployed on a more regular basis to manage current account deficits. Capital flows will need to revive going forward.

While the scheme has fulfilled its primary objective, it is not a costless exercise. The reason why it attracted such large inflows was the highly attractive returns being offered to the depositors. The RBI has offered to cover the costs of currency depreciation for the banks offering these deposits and its closure has seen rates being revised down by three percentage points. The cost will eventually reflect in things such as lower RBI dividends to the exchequer overtime.

Its medium to long-term implications aside, the scheme will also have an immediate fallout. The most important of them all is the sharp spike in banking system liquidity, which data shows increased from ₹1.85 lakh crore on June 5 to ₹7.8 lakh crore on September 1. This will have to be taken care of by the central bank via various policy interventions.

Is there a simpler takeaway beyond these technical details? It is the following: India's macro-credibility, when backed with the sovereign's commitment, remains strong with investors. The challenge is to make India's markets as convincing about their long-term returns.

When no number high enough is enough

The 7.8% first quarter growth in a world in turmoil is not enough to satisfy the sceptics. We should ignore the noise and carry on with reskilling, reform and growth

Just two months ago, the dominant story was of doom. The oil price rise due to the West Asia war, outflow of capital and rupee depreciation were all cited as reasons to prove that India was in a downward spiral. The external shock, it was said, revealed the real problems of the Indian economy. Most people don't roll over and die. They respond to crisis. Quick moves by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) offering a rupee dollar swap window to attract NRI deposits stemmed the rupee slide and had to be discontinued due to the positive inflows.

Even before the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MOSPI) released the first quarter data on August 31, the high frequency indicators were already telling the story of a strong growth spurt in the months when everything went wrong. Industrial production, vehicle registration, goods exports, corporate earnings were showing green. The 7.8% first quarter GDP growth is built on both manufacturing growing at 9.2% and services at

10%, with both consumption and capital formation doing well.

A gym body does not happen overnight. It takes years of careful eating and regular workouts. The steadiness of the Indian economy today comes on the back of tough decisions and financial prudence manoeuvred by the finance minister and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). The hawk-like focus on the fiscal deficit number post-Covid has reduced it to 4.4%, down a full 200 basis points from FY 2022-23. This gave the government elbow room to absorb the oil price shock, removing the risk of runaway inflation. The push to manufacturing, and exports, and the focus on deregulation and decriminalisation of laws are all arrows in the quiver of reform. But sceptics remain unconvinced.

The biggest criticism is that the government reduced last year's numbers to make this year look good. One former finance secretary has made the allegation that FY 2022-23 numbers were reduced to give the 7.8% number. The problem with this argument is that data from two different statistical series are being taken into account and compared. Think of it this way: If the measuring tape changes, you have to go back and use the new tape to measure last year's data to remeasure before you compare it with the present.

We know that India is in the process of moving to a new GDP series with a new base year — all countries do this. For the Q1 2026-27

estimate, the statistical system is effectively dealing with two different series — the older series and the new series — and the historical data have been revised to make the new series comparable.

There is an additional problem with the argument that data is fudged. The GDP computation makes billions of transactions across millions of aggregated data points, collected from diversified sources. It is humanly impossible to tinker with these data points in any meaningful manner.

The methodology has been developed after vast consultations over the past few years and the use of actual data, not just surveys, has been a change for the better.

For example, there are data sets that report on GST data, industrial production, consumption of steel, air traffic, results of listed companies, deposit and credit growth, vehicle sales data from e-VAHAN, food offtake data, tolls collected and many more.

The argument then moves to inflation: Inflation data is wrong because prices 'feel' higher. It is impossible to build a metro index that takes into account the inflation experience of each individual. The average height of a class might be five feet, but there will be individuals much shorter or taller.

Averages are important to compare the direction of change as well as to allow us to collapse into a number the average experience of the group. So, if inflation 'feels' higher to you,



The steadiness of the Indian economy today comes on the back of tough decisions and financial prudence manoeuvred by the finance minister and the Reserve Bank of India.

HT ARCHIVE



Monika Halan

then it simply means that your consumption basket is not the average CPI basket. The July inflation point at 4.45% is well below the higher 6% band that RBI must not breach.

Then it shifts to the falling rupee. The rupee is falling, and that shows the weakness of the economy. But what is less understood is that the weakness of the rupee is related to inflation being managed and kept within a band of 2% to 6% by the RBI. A country has to choose between running an independent monetary policy that is setting interest rates to manage inflation, and a fixed exchange rate. India has chosen the former as runaway inflation is harmful to everyone.

If exchange rates are market-linked, then the rupee will react to market forces. RBI's quick action in gathering NRI dollars has stopped both the rupee slide and the doom-day talking heads. But, what about stock markets, they are still down. True. While the domestic investment case is gathering momentum, the

global capital flows remain an important source of volatility. Remember that the world is at its most unstable since the two world wars. However, July and August have seen the beginnings of a return of FI money into Indian equity, with net inflows of around \$500,000 crore over the two months, after months of net outflows.

India is in a unique position in the world with high growth rates and low inflation amidst a very difficult global environment which is unlikely to change anytime soon. At the government, corporate and individual level we must not let down the guard.

And while we should criticise the government for urban planning, air quality, corruption and so on, the macroeconomic stability that has come by design and not chance, must be celebrated.

Monika Halan is the best-selling author of the Let's Talk series of books on money. The views expressed are personal



WHAT IS THE REAL CONSTRAINT ON INDIA'S NUCLEAR AMBITION?

{ RAHUL TONGIA } RESEARCHER

Nuclear ecosystem's big risk is safe fuel supply, not finance

Nuclear power divides people. While some environmentalists value its zero-carbon energy, others worry about its safety, weapons potential and waste-management risks, not to mention cost, especially when renewable energy is getting cheaper. But many countries are eyeing it for the same reason India is: energy security. NITI Aayog's net-zero study projected a cost-effective greener pathway would need ~100 GW of nuclear power by 2047, a more than 10x growth from now.

Many supporters of nuclear power projects in India have held the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act, 2010, responsible for making it difficult for India to attract foreign entrants. Now, India has signed the SHANTI Act, 2025, which caps the liability for nuclear power system developers, specifically removing the automatic liability for equipment suppliers. This is vital since the operator could be Indian but equipment would invariably come from abroad.

Traditionally, India's nuclear power programme was domestically based, with a three-phase plan going from natural uranium in Pressurised Heavy Water Reactors (PHWRs) — to plutonium in fast breeder reactors, to thorium-based reactors over time. To accelerate the installed capacity of nuclear power, India opened up its sector to international collaboration, including under the A123 deal signed with the US in 2008. It was a period of hope, but few global partnerships materialised — Russia being a notable exception, with work on the Kudankulam plant predating the A123 deal.

The SHANTI Act is a welcome move, but will it suffice? To truly scale nuclear power, India's planning will have to think beyond just liability towards a more holistic view of risk.

Global experience, especially with international collaborations, shows that the real risks for nuclear power beyond accidents span cost overruns to never getting built. With that lens, we need to look at other dimensions.

Finance is the easiest to scope. Is the global supplier bringing in capital? At what rate? In rupees? Is the project set up to be paid in fixed \$/kWh electricity or is it a capex play (leaving operators as a risk)? For India, details about fuel and fuel cycles matter more. But when it comes to nuclear power plants, India chose PHWR technology, which is not what most countries use. India lacks enrichment facilities to convert natural uranium, which can only be directly used by PHWRs. Enrich a little Lightly Enriched Uranium (LEU) and it's usable in light water reactors (LWRs), but enrich much more and you can make a bomb.

Thus, for typical reactors based on LEU, India would need a secure supply for fuel. This is before considering the question of what happens to spent fuel. Will the supplier be willing to take it back?

Established infrastructure players such as Tata, Adani, National Thermal Power Corpo-

To truly scale nuclear power, India's planning will have to think beyond just liability towards a more holistic view of risk



ration have expressed interest in nuclear power. They would all need to build contracts around. Not just nuclear technology (hardware) but also assured fuel supply. India is in a position to ask for not just fuel but even LEU production facilities as part of a package deal. India can ameliorate global concerns by placing such contracts and linked reactors open to external inspections. Such facilities would take time. Is that worth it? Given the scale of nuclear power planned, it should be, and initially, LEU fuel can be imported.

If one is making a wish list, new fuel cycles, especially based on thorium, which India has in abundance, are worth developing. Not only does this address fuel security, such fuel cycles can also lead to lower spent fuel nuclear waste problems.

Let's say that the entire deal is worked out as a package. A mix of entities come together and develop technology, finance, and LEU fuel. And the plant gets built and starts running. The question remains: How sure are we that fuel would be available for a lifespan of 50+ years? How does a country manage the risk of geopolitical considerations trumping commercial ones? These aspects aren't independent — technology transfer can be both commercial and strategic, where the intellectual property owner doesn't want the buyer to end up becoming a competitor.

Ultimately, the SHANTI Act is a vital step forward, but the real work now moves to building the ecosystems around new nuclear power technologies. India will have to take explicit calls on the interplay between costs, security, and environmental concerns — the inevitable "energy trilemma" facing policy-makers worldwide.

Rahul Tongia is a senior fellow, Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP), a not-for-profit think tank. The views expressed are personal

{ RIA SINHA AND ABHINAV JINDAL } RESEARCHERS

Nuclear capacity needs new financing tools, patient capital

India's decision to expand nuclear power capacity from around 8 GW to 100 GW by 2047 represents one of the most ambitious infrastructure programmes in the country's history. Achieving this target is expected to require investments of approximately \$22-24 billion over the next two decades. While much of the policy debate has centred on liability laws, reactor technologies and private-sector participation, India's nuclear ambitions will ultimately depend on whether it can build a financing architecture capable of mobilising capital at unprecedented scale and for sufficiently long durations.

The problem is not simply that nuclear power is presently expensive. It is that the financial ecosystem required to support such long-gestation projects has yet to evolve. A utility-scale solar project in India typically costs \$3.5-5 crore per MW, while coal-fired plants require around \$8-10 crore per MW. Large nuclear reactors, by comparison, can cost \$15-20 crore per MW. Yet the headline capital cost tells only part of the story. Because nuclear projects typically require eight to ten years before generating revenue, financing becomes a critical determinant of project viability.

International studies suggest that financing costs can account for 30%-50% of the levelised cost of nuclear electricity. The Govt's Roadmap for Achieving 100 GW Nuclear Capacity by 2047 estimates a borrowing cost of around 9%, under which Interest During Construction (IDC) alone accounts for nearly 15%-20% of total project cost. Every additional year of construction delay compounds financing costs, raising tariffs and eroding project economics. While any reduction in cost of capital has a salutary effect on financing costs for the underlying generation technology, in case of nuclear it may have a greater impact on affordability than marginal reductions in engineering or equipment costs. Private investment will also depend on the underlying risk-return profile. Investors compare nuclear projects with renewable energy transmission, battery storage and other infrastructure assets that often require lower upfront investment, shorter construction periods and lower execution risk. If expected returns are broadly similar, capital naturally gravitates towards projects with lower opportunity costs and faster capital recycling.

Equally important is recognising that balance-sheet financing alone may not deliver a 100 GW programme. Even India's largest public enterprises and industrial groups cannot indefinitely loan up enormous amounts of capital in projects that may take a decade before generating cash flows. At the scale envisioned, India would need to mobilise roughly ₹1 lakh crore every year for more than two decades.

Nuclear projects may also require a larger viability-gap-funding (VGF) envelope than solar, wind or battery storage because of their much higher upfront capital needs and construction risk. Rather than relying on one-time budgetary support, VGF could be combined with low-cost long-term loans, construction-period interest

As nuclear projects require 8-10 years before generating revenue, financing becomes a critical determinant of viability



subvention, sovereign or partial credit guarantees, and post-commissioning refinancing. The objective should be to use public support to crowd in commercial capital, not replace it. India today has insurance companies, pension funds and provident funds managing assets worth well over ₹100 lakh crore, yet little of this long-term capital reaches nuclear infrastructure or green infrastructure more broadly. A post-commissioning refinancing market through infrastructure bonds, INVIT-like structures or other long-term instruments could release bank and sponsor capital for subsequent reactors.

Construction risk also needs sharper allocation. Delays arising from changes in law, regulatory approvals or force majeure should not be treated like delays caused by project management or contractor underperformance. Automatically passing all IDC to consumers weakens incentives for efficient execution. Costs should instead be borne by the parties best placed to manage them.

International experience offers useful lessons. France relied heavily on state-backed utility finance. South Korea combined utility finance with policy-bank support and standardised fleet construction, and China has used State-owned utilities and banks alongside domestic manufacturing. India has already undertaken important regulatory reforms to enable wider participation and strengthen domestic manufacturing. Financial innovation can reinforce these reforms. Existing instruments, public financial institutions, infrastructure bonds, credit guarantees, long-term lending, insurance and institutional capital provide a base that can be adapted rather than built from scratch. Used in a coordinated manner, they can lower financing costs, recycle capital and make nuclear projects progressively more investable. India's 100 GW target, therefore, is more a financial innovation challenge.

Ria Sinha is senior fellow, Chintan Research Foundation and Abhinav Jindal is a senior economist. The views expressed are personal

HT
'Canada ready for US trade deal that benefits both sides'
OTTAWA: Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said on Thursday his government was ready to sign a trade deal with the US that benefits both countries, adding any agreement would need to have stability and credibility. **REUTERS**

Trump admin's bid limiting birthright citizenship blocked
WASHINGTON: A US federal judge on Wednesday blocked the Trump administration from enforcing a new executive order limiting who qualifies for birthright citizenship. The move thwarts President Donald Trump's latest attempt to restrict the constitutional right, which comes after the US Supreme Court rejected his previous effort. **AFP**

Apple faces \$2.7bn UK lawsuit over app tracking rules
LONDON: Apple is facing a £2 billion (\$2.7 billion) London lawsuit brought on behalf of app developers over its app tracking rules, with the iPhone maker accused of abusing its power to unfairly impose greater restrictions on third parties. **REUTERS**

37 die from fumes during oil pipeline theft in Nigeria
PORT HARCOURT: At least 37 people died on Thursday in Nigeria's oil-rich southern Niger Delta after inhaling fumes during the theft of fuel from a pipeline, a local NGO said. **AFP**

Iran targets Kuwait even as it mourns victims of US strike

Reuters
letters@hindustantimes.com
DUBAI: Iranian mourners carried caskets on Thursday at a funeral for victims of a US airstrike said to have struck a wedding party, and Tehran launched missiles and drones overnight at a US base in Kuwait, after the war's biggest escalation in more than a month. Mourners assembled in the late afternoon outside the village of Kubeisak in Sirik County, along a stretch of the coast of the Strait of Hormuz that was hit by heavy US airstrikes late on Tuesday. Iranian officials say four people died and nearly 70 were wounded by a strike that hit a home during a wedding. State TV reported on Thursday that a fifth person, a 22-year-old woman, had since died in hospital. The US military said it was aware of the Iranian reports but that it "never targets civilians". "This is the body of Martyr Amir-Mohammad Karimi, a 4-year-old child who was martyred in an attack on the country's south by the criminal American regime," a reporter from Iran's Mehr news agency said in footage filmed in front of a pickup truck carrying a flag-draped coffin beneath a canopy of palm fronds. In other footage of the funeral, mourners threw petals into the air as doleful music played from a loudspeaker. A casket was carried past a row of soldiers standing at attention with rifles. "If it was a military location, it wouldn't be so painful. This was a wedding ceremony, but they turned people's joy into mourning," the semi-official Tasnim news agency quoted a local man as saying. Washington launched the airstrikes on Tuesday, hitting what it said were military targets along the coast in retaliation for Iranian attacks on shipping in the Strait of



A residential building was damaged following an Iranian drone attack in Kuwait City on Thursday. **AFP**

SEAFARERS' DEATHS: SAUDI ACCUSES IRAN OF ATTACK ON TANKER

RIYADH: Saudi Arabia has claimed that Iran targeted an oil tanker, the Sifir, as it transited through the Strait of Hormuz, resulting in fatalities among the vessel's crew. In an official statement, Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs expressed stern condemnation of the action. In the statement, Riyadh extended its condemnation to broader regional military action, citing Iranian attacks directed at Jordan, Bahrain, and Kuwait. **ANI**

Hormuz. The sudden escalation of the Iran war has caused a surge in oil prices to levels unseen since July. Price rose for a fourth straight day on Thursday, taking Brent crude futures over \$96 a barrel. Iran reported 18 dead in the last US assault, including the four killed at the wedding. It responded on Wednesday to the US strikes with attacks on US bases in Iraq, Jordan, Qatar, Kuwait and Bahrain, and carried

HEGSETH EXTENDS U.S. DEPLOYMENT INTO 2027 IN WEST ASIA

NEW DELHI: US defence secretary Pete Hegseth has extended West Asia military deployment in a sign that the war could drag well into next year, the Wall Street Journal (WSJ) reported on Thursday. The deployment of 19 warships, air defence units, fighter squadrons and paratroopers in US war campaign against Iran, is straining service members, the Journal reported, quoting people familiar with the matter. **HTC**

{ UKRAINE WAR } DEAL TO SUPPLY ARTILLERY SHELLS

Estonian defence minister quits over botched EU-funded deal involving Indian firm

HTC & Agencies
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NEW DELHI: Estonia's defence minister Hanno Pevkur resigned from government following a furore over a botched European Union-funded deal to buy artillery shells for Ukraine from a company owned by an Indian entity, which denied allegations of wrongdoing.

Pevkur, who has been in office since 2022, announced his decision in a TV appearance late on Wednesday. He has been the longest-serving minister since Estonia gained independence in 1991 and is well-known internationally.

On Wednesday, Estonian newspaper Eesti Ekspress reported that in 2024 Estonia made a deal for shells with Italian-registered company Datasel SRL, which, it stated, is owned by the Indian company Neco Defence Munitions. Neither firm had produced shells before, it reported.

Pevkur has been facing calls to resign after the Estonian Prosecu-



Hanno Pevkur **AFP**

Ramesh Jayaswal, director at Jayaswal Neco Industries—the parent company of Neco Defence System Pvt Ltd—disputed the reporting and told HT: "We supplied artillery shells following quality checks by concerned Estonian officials. They subsequently awarded us more contracts but later halted them due to a lack of funds."

The funding for the deal was provided by the EU as part of a

multi-billion-euro effort to shore up Kyiv's weapons stocks at a time when 155mm artillery shells were in short supply. The defence ministry's procurement agency made large upfront payments to the company in 2024 to secure deliveries.

Estonian defence officials have also launched a lawsuit against the supplier at a European arbitration court. Pevkur faced a grilling by lawmakers at a public special committee session on Wednesday morning. He called the situation an "ordinary contract dispute", that had to be judged in the context of international pressure to urgently aid Kyiv's defences against Russia's invasion amid a global shortage of weapons supply.

Estonia's defence procurement agency has prided itself for being fast and nimble, putting it in a position to act as a facilitator for other European nations buying weapons for Ukraine. It has executed around €400 million (\$464 million) in contracts on behalf of international donors, according to Pevkur.

'NEPAL NEEDS TO REBUILD NEARLY 20,000 HOUSES IN FLOOD-HIT AREAS'

Reuters
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KATHMANDU: Nepal will have to rebuild around 20,000 houses in flood-ravaged areas, authorities said on Thursday, as rescuers continued to search for workers trapped in tunnels linked to hydropower projects and thousands remain missing after last week's catastrophe.

A glacier collapse on August 26 sent a deluge of ice, rock and mud sweeping through the impoverished nation's border region with China, wiping out settlements and villages and leaving few houses standing and undamaged.

"Our preliminary estimates are that 7,500 houses have been completely destroyed, either washed away or buried under debris and mud," Dharma Raj Upreti, chief of the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), told Reuters.

Even houses still standing were not habitable, Upreti said, with authorities estimating that around 20,000 houses would have to be rebuilt in different, safer locations. At least 1,252 people were killed in Nepal last week as houses, streets and schools in towns and villages near the border with China's Tibet were swept away.

Deadlock in US over Russia sanctions bill

Shashank Mattoo
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WASHINGTON: The political deadlock over the Sanctioning Russia Act—which threatens up to 100% tariffs on India and four other countries for buying Russian energy—continued in Washington on Thursday, despite an intense lobbying effort by Ukraine to secure the bill's passage in the House of Representatives.

Influential Congressman Gregory Meeks—who has led opposition within the Democratic Party to the bill—met with Vladyslav Vlasuk, a top adviser to Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, who has backed the bill.

Meeks emerged from the meeting on Wednesday stating publicly that he will continue to oppose the bill on the grounds that it grants too much tariff authority to President Trump.

Meeks' statement comes amid disagreements within the opposition Democratic party about the bill. Members of the party in the Senate were enthusiastic backers of the bill, playing a role in its passage in the upper house by a decisive 85-12 margin. The lawmakers have urged their colleagues in the House to pass the Sanctioning Russia Act, complete with the tariff provisions. For his part, Meeks has called for a "good-faith compromise" that would place eco-

nomic pressure on Russia to end the war while addressing concerns like-minded lawmakers have about the tariff provisions.

These disagreements continue even as the House of Representatives and the Senate reconvened this week after a recess in August. Persons aware of the matter on Capitol Hill told HT that substantial uncertainty remained as to when the bill would be introduced for a vote. The Democratic Party will attempt to bridge internal divides through this week, minority leader Representative Hakeem Jeffries was quoted as saying in US media reports.

Some believed that the visit of China's President Xi Jinping in late September has played a role in delaying a vote on the bill. The bill targets the top five purchasers of Russian energy, which would include China. The Trump administration may, the people added, seek to delay a vote on the Russia sanctions bill until after Xi's visit is concluded.

Trump administration officials have given mixed signals about the extent of their support for the bill. US Ambassador to India Sergio Goro notably downplayed President Trump's support for the Russia sanctions bill in New Delhi last month. However, Secretary of State Marco Rubio took aim at the Democrats for holding up passage of the bill in the House.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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Nvidia buys AI platform Hugging Face for \$13 bn

Reuters

feedback@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Nvidia will buy popular developer platform Hugging Face for \$12.5 billion, betting that support for open AI models will drive future demand even as its biggest customers develop their own chips to reduce reliance on the semiconductor giant.

Shares of the company were up 1.5% after the deal was announced on Thursday, which ranks among its biggest.

The deal will cement Nvidia as a central player in the market for open models that users can freely download, run and customise, unlike the closed systems built by OpenAI and Anthropic. Nvidia has already played an active role in backing the open AI industry with its widely used Nemotron model.

Acquiring Hugging Face will give it direct access to a platform developers use to create, test and share tools using various open AI models, potentially providing valuable insight and data to help it narrow the tech-



Jensen Huang, CEO, Nvidia.

nology gap with top U.S. and Chinese labs.

Demand for open-weight models has surged from businesses banking on the steep bill of deploying the technology, with Chinese companies such as DeepSeek and Z.ai emerging as crucial players with models that can match the best from the U.S. in tasks, including generating computer code at a lower cost.

That surge has fueled fears that some American firms could become reliant on Beijing's models as both countries race to dominate a technology they see as crucial to their future.

"Hugging Face will remain an

open platform for the entire AI ecosystem," Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang said, adding that his company's chips would not be required to build on or deploy through Hugging Face.

Under the deal, Nvidia will pay about \$11.9 billion to Hugging Face investors, while offering an equity-based retention program of up to \$1 billion for employees who join Nvidia.

The two companies already work together to help developers use Nvidia's computing services on the platform.

Hugging Face was valued at \$4.5 billion in its last disclosed funding round in August 2023,

when it raised \$235 million from investors such as Salesforce, AMD and Amazon.

Nvidia, meanwhile, exited its July quarter with \$224.4 billion in cash and cash equivalents, more than double January's \$10.61 billion, giving the chipmaker substantial capacity to fund the deal.

That financial strength reflects a rapidly expanding business. Last late month, Nvidia issued a rare year-ahead outlook, forecasting revenue growth of about 70% in fiscal 2028 as the AI infrastructure boom rages on.

But the chipmaker's use of its balance sheet has also drawn scrutiny. Deals such as its agreement to guarantee up to \$105 billion for OpenAI's Ohio data-center lease have intensified investor concerns that Nvidia is supporting the demand driving its growth. For Nvidia, building up open source may help it cushion a demand slowdown from customers such as Meta, OpenAI and Microsoft, which are developing their own AI chips to cut reliance on its costly and supply-constrained processors.

India awaits comparative advantage to seal US deal

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: The government is focused on maximising the utilisation of free trade agreements (FTAs) after securing preferential access to two-thirds of the global market through nine trade deals, commerce minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday, even as India is on course to forge several more FTAs with major economies such as the US, Canada and Chile.

Goyal, who is scheduled to visit the US later this month, said finalisation of the interim bilateral trade agreement (BITA) with Washington awaits a tariff structure that gives India a comparative advantage over its competitors.

India and the US finalised a framework for an interim BITA on February 2, but an agreement could not be signed after the US Supreme Court invalidated the legal basis for the preferential tariff Washington had offered.

"As soon as the US is able to give us the preferential rate in comparison to our competition, we will finalise the BITA and announce the final details," Goyal said at a workshop on FTA utilisation.

India has concluded nine



Piyush Goyal, commerce and industry minister.

FTAs under the Narendra Modi government, ensuring that each provides India exporters a comparative advantage in the respective markets, Goyal said. Since 2021, India has signed and operationalised FTAs with Mauritius, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Australia, the European Free Trade Association (EFTA), Oman and the UK. FTAs with New Zealand and the EU are in the process of being operationalised, while the framework of an interim BITA with the US has been agreed, pending finalisation of the tariff architecture.

According to trade experts, India is facing several tariff actions by the US. A 10% tariff has already been imposed on several labour-intensive goods this July for alleged use of forced

labour under Section 301, they said, requesting anonymity. The threat of another penal tariff is looming as the US has launched another Section 301 investigation into alleged excess industrial capacity. All such uncertainties must be resolved to conclude a fair, equitable and mutually beneficial trade agreement, they said.

Apart from the India-US BITA, India is expected to conclude several bilateral trade deals over the next few months to couple of years, Goyal said, referring to ongoing talks with Canada, Mexico, Chile, Mercosur, the South African Customs Union (SACU), the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) and Israel. Referring to these potential trade deals, along with ongoing efforts to review and expand existing FTAs with ASEAN, South Korea and Japan, Goyal said such trade arrangements would secure greater market access and give India access to 75% of global trade at rates lower than those faced by its competitors.

Government officials, who did not want to be named, said India is very close to finalising a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) with Chile, a country rich in critical minerals.

SEBI PLANS PAPER ON CLOSING AUCTION SESSION

Apoorva Ajith

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MUMBAI: The stock market regulator on Thursday said it will review how settlement prices for derivative contracts are determined, following industry feedback on the impact of the new closing auction session (CAS) on expiry-day pricing. A consultation paper proposing changes to the methodology is likely next week, even as the one-month-old CAS remains marred by low participation and occasional abrupt price swings.

Designed to enhance pricing transparency, CAS was introduced in the equity cash segment for 213 derivative-traded stocks on 3 August. The closing price, established by matching the maximum number of buy and sell orders in the last 15 minutes of trading, is also used to determine settlement prices for derivative contracts on expiry.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India said it had monitored the functioning of CAS closely and held discussions with market participants.

Under the CAS framework, market participants once used to full price visibility at the day's end now wait in suspense, as the auction and pricing mechanism plays out over the last 15 minutes. On Thursday, the BSE Sensex plunged about 2,100 points in the first five minutes of the auction session, only to recover soon after. The index ultimately closed 417 points lower at 76,152.86.

Trade volumes during CAS declined 24.3% from 3 August to 19.6 million on 28 August, while the trade value dropped 26% to \$944.94 crore, NSE data showed. Participation recovered at the end of the month following the MSCI index rebalancing on 31 August. By 3 September, volumes rose by 4.7%, while value rose 14.2% to ₹1,457.74 crore.

It was not only the cash market which was struggling about half of the volume and value in Bank Nifty futures vanished since CAS was introduced.

Volumes fell 42% to 14,180 contracts, while value declined similarly to ₹2,445.72 crore on 2 September.

KENYA ORDERS TATA CHEMICALS TO STOP ITS OPERATIONS

Reuters

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NAIROBI: Kenya's President William Ruto said on Thursday that he had ordered India's Tata Chemicals to stop its operations in Kenya, saying its presence had failed to benefit the country.

Ruto said the government would bring in two new companies to take over operations for Tata Chemicals.

In late July, Tata had said Kenya's government had ordered its unit Tata Chemical Limited to suspend its operations at the Magadi Soda factory and suspended any exports of soda ash.

"That TATA company ... had that contract for 100 years. They have not built anything in Kajiado, they have not built any factory in Kajiado," Ruto said during a visit to the region in southern Kenya.

"We have said we will bring a new company and... they should put a big glass company here in Kajiado. And another company to make chemicals here in Kajiado. Are we slaves to other people?" The company could not immediately be reached for comment on Ruto's decision and his criticism.

SERVICES SECTOR GROWTH EXPANDS AT SLOWEST PACE IN FOUR YEARS

Shreya Khandelwal

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NEW DELHI: India's private services sector expanded in August compared to July, but the expansion (excluding July) remained weakest since March 2022, according to the HSBC India Services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) data released by S&P Global on Thursday.

"Growth was supported by stronger output and new business, although the overall pace was still among the weakest seen in over four years, with some firms citing subdued bookings, competition and reduced transport operations," said Pranjal Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC.

The seasonally adjusted services PMI Business Activity Index stood at 54.1 in August compared to 53.3 in July, and was below its long-run average of 54.5. Barring the previous month's figure, the August value is the lowest since March 2022 when the index stood at 53.6. To be sure, a reading above 50 separates expansion from contraction; the index has maintained this level since August 2021.

The broader composite picture remained the same as last month, matching the level last observed in February 2021. The Composite Index—which accounts for both manufacturing and services—came in at 54.3 in August. Buoyant activity in the service sector offset the weaker activity of the manufacturing sector which grew at its slowest pace in August, helping maintain the same level in July.

Tata clears key hurdle in chairman search

Bloomberg

feedback@hindustantimes.com

Tata Trusts said it received relief in a regulatory probe, potentially allowing the controlling shareholder of Tata Group's holding company to resume business as usual as it seeks to pick a new chairman. The Trusts received an order from the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner dated September 2, closing a complaint related to a 1959 share transfer, according to a statement Thursday. That complaint had triggered restrictions that prevented one of the Trusts from convening internal meetings.

The relief comes as a boost at a time of heightened leadership uncertainty triggered by Natarajan Chandrasekaran's unexpected decision to step down as chairman of Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd. Ratan Tata Trust, one of the 13 Tata charities, had been unable to nominate a member for the new chairman-selection process because of the curbs.

Tata Trusts owns 66% in Tata Sons—which oversees the listed companies of the sprawling group that owns Taj hotels to Tetley tea. The 23 companies under the group's umbrella—of which 26 are publicly listed—generated a combined revenue of about \$85 billion in the year ended March 31.

THE RELIEF COMES AS A BOOST AT A TIME OF HEIGHTENED LEADERSHIP UNCERTAINTY

The Charity Commissioner's probe relates to a petition filed by Vijay Singh, a trustee of Tata Trusts. He alleged that \$33 Tata Sons shares were improperly transferred from the Navajbai Ratan Tata Trust to Naval H. Tata without fair consideration, valid documentation, or proper approvals. These shares were subsequently inherited by

Naval's sons—Ratan, Noel, and Jimmy Tata. Tata Trusts said the allegations were "part of a willful, malicious and orchestrated campaign" to discredit the Tata Group's philanthropic arm.

The dismissal of the complaint strengthens the position of Noel Tata, head of Tata Trusts, at a moment when the group is seeking to reassure shareholders, market regulators and policymakers about its stability. It also bolsters confidence that the conglomerate can continue delivering on initiatives central to PM Narendra Modi's ambitions to turn India into a global technology and manufacturing powerhouse.

SC closes SEBI-NSE case after ₹1,500-cr settlement

Press Trust of India

feedback@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday disposed of pleas by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) against the National Stock Exchange (NSE) in the co-location and dark fibre cases after the market regulator approved around ₹1,500-crore settlement with the exchange.

The co-location and dark fibre cases relate to allegations that certain stockbrokers received unfair, preferential speed advantages to access mar-

ket data and trade before other investors. A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran took note of the settlement proposed and disposed of the petitions filed by SEBI.

In July, the NSE paid Rs 714.74 crore to SEBI after receiving the regulator's in-principle approval to settle the long-pending co-location and dark fibre cases for ₹1,491.21 crore.

The latest payment, together with the ₹776.47 crore already deposited by the NSE, completes the ₹1,491.21-crore settlement amount agreed under the revised settlement terms.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

- 1 It isn't much to ask for (7)
- 2 Greatly resented being worked to death (5)
- 3 Old joke (4)
- 4 It's just the same as what is put on disc (8)
- 5 Deduces that the tour season has been ruined (13)
- 6 Spread out (6)
- 7 New ethics people find irritating (6)
- 8 Sends a plea for restoration of seaside walks (10)
- 9 A developing area (8)
- 10 Open to defeat (4)
- 11 To do so the wrong way will go against the grain (13)
- 12 Properties on the US Atlantic seaboard (7)

DOWN

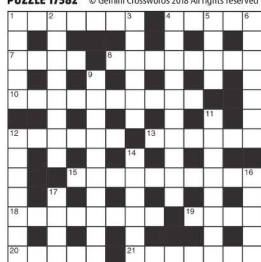
- 1 Property more important (5)
- 2 I'd take up a position some way away (8)
- 3 Humble a good person, after a fashion (6)
- 4 Thus India gets confused by the vernacular (10)
- 5 Hard work one gets very much upset about (4)
- 6 Where some spend the rest of the afternoon (14)
- 7 Humour's excursion is usually good for a laugh (5,5)
- 8 Question commonly posed by a detective novel (8)
- 9 Sack and what may be put in it (7)
- 10 Opening vocal variation to Elgar's First (5)
- 11 Worn parts of brakes (5)
- 12 Not a fair copy (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17581)

CRYPTIC
 N E E D L E C R A F T
 G N O A S E L
 I N D O O R S V E N I E
 A L P H A B E T I C
 D O C T O R A N G H O R
 T I M E T O C O I N
 S U R M I S E
 I R A T E B R A Z I L
 S I E S T R A I G H T

QUICK
 O L I V E R I A N O H
 R E O U G U R O
 U R A N I U M C U R I O
 A L O P A
 B U I T K E E P I T O P
 R I B B O N T E R R O R
 S U P N O P
 A L O V A N A
 P O I S T A M B I E N T
 O N T H E A G E N D A

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QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
- 1 Begin a voyage (3,4)
 - 4 Deprived of (5)
 - 5 Allowable deviation (6)
 - 8 Worshipping problem (8)
 - 10 Justifiably (4,6)
 - 12 Cherry red (4)
 - 13 Without restriction (6)
 - 15 Mutually hostile (2,3,5)
 - 16 Unrestricted admission (4,4)
 - 18 Transaction (4)
 - 20 Churlish (5)
 - 21 Be aware of beforehand (7)
- DOWN**
- 1 Scatter loosely (5)
 - 2 Uncommunicative (8)
 - 3 Allowable deviation (6)
 - 4 Inferior quality (10)
 - 5 Small notch (4)
 - 6 Nonsense expressly (7)
 - 7 Modern (7,3)
 - 11 Proximity (8)
 - 12 Unfeeling (7)
 - 14 Distant (3,3)
 - 16 Find answer to (5)
 - 17 A tree-borne fruit (4)

{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE HIGH + LOW

FRIDAY Generally cloudy sky with Light Rain or Drizzle

SATURDAY Generally cloudy sky with Light Rain

SUNDAY Generally cloudy sky with Light Rain

29°C | 21°C 29°C | 21°C 29°C | 21°C

ALMANAC

Today is 4 September 2026

15th of Ashvini, 1628

15th of Ashvini, 1628

15th of Ashvini, 1628

15th of Ashvini, 1628

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 32°C | 26°C

Mumbai 32°C | 26°C

Kolkata 32°C | 28°C

Chennai 32°C | 27°C

Bengaluru 29°C | 21°C

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A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

BCCI backs Rohit, says too much cricket hurting team

In review meeting among stakeholders, many concern areas were raised with no easy solutions

Rashesh Mandani
rashesh.mandani@htlive.com

MUMBAI: "Rohit Sharma is playing superbly in all matches. So what more do you want?" With that rhetorical expression, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia gave the former India captain additional time to convince the selectors that he had the required mileage for another ODI World Cup campaign.

Saikia's media comments came minutes after attending a BCCI forward-planning gathering that also comprised ODI captain Shubman Gill and head coach Gautam Gambhir.

The national selection committee led by Ajit Agarkar had noticed signs of slumping benchmarks in the 39-year-old's bat-fresh gear against West Indies last time. Although cramps troubled him toward the back-half of that innings, it was a statement knock under immense pressure in light of speculations of impending retirement.

The next World Cup is a little over a year away, which can quickly look distant to him now, Rohit has the board's backing. In the last match, he scored 138 runs, so why is there speculation? I don't want to give fodder for speculators," said Saikia.

To make it to the 2027 World Cup, which Saikia called "the ultimate goal" for the Indian cricket team, Rohit will take fresh guard against West Indies starting September 27.

Too much cricket

The "soul searching" exercise as Saikia put it, was an attempt to iron out past scheduling and planning shortcomings, which manifested as inconsistent Test cricket performance and a decline in white-ball results across bilateral series.

"There are too many matches in the year," Saikia admitted. After winning the T20 World Cup, India has undertaken trips to Ireland and England. They are scheduled to play Afghanistan in Dubai, followed by the Asian Games in Japan, then away matches against New Zealand, before closing the year with home matches against Sri Lanka. Few teams have been omitted from such a spread of bilateral cricket, that too across formats.

The ODI team's engagements



(Clockwise L-R) Rohit Sharma, Gautam Gambhir and Shreyas Iyer. VVS Laxman, Shubman Gill.

are equally busy. A case in point is the upcoming West Indies ODI series clashing with the Asian Games, forcing the selectors to release some ODI regulars for the T20 medal hunt. BCCI's fostering of bedroom friendships has also contributed to an overcrowded calendar, leaving even Indian cricket's vast bench strength, strained.

"In the next FTP (future tours programme), we will take certain measures. We have instructed that our FTP should be for the players as well. They have some kind of acclimatisation or friendly matches before any major series in SENA (South Africa, England, New Zealand, Australia) countries," the board secretary said.

In the immediate future, the Test team will face the brunt of a jam-packed itinerary. A shadow tour comprising three four-day matches has been scheduled before the New Zealand Test-series in November, which will

determine India's chances for the World Test Championship final. But a bulk of that action will run parallel with India's white-ball action in New Zealand. Gill will be among several other two-format players who will have to pick and choose. It's precisely such ill-planned schedules that Gill has raised concerns over in the past, and he is known to have made his views known again in a meeting.

For next year's marquee series against Australia, the team management sentiment is that the batters should get a platform to improve their play against the turning ball, allowing them to push for turning tracks. That can be achieved by preparing challenging pitches in the upcoming A series at home against Australia, but it could also be counter-productive, helping the opponents sharpen their game.

The operations team led by BCCI General Manager Abey Kuruvilla is tasked with devising a strategy for India to regain Test

dominance at home.

Fitness protocols

The excessive matches have also hit the players' fitness, but there are other structural shortcomings at the Centre of Excellence (COE) too. The swanky new COE facility in Bengaluru has been without a sports science head for nearly 18 months. On the record, Saikia played down the impact of a leadership vacuum in the sports science wing. "I would like to reiterate once more that the vacant position of the head of sports science is not a deterrent to our activities in COE. That post is required (to be filled), but that is a very high-level post and a proper qualified person should be positioned," he said.

There were discussions, though, that return-to-play protocols would have to be strengthened. Both Gill and Gambhir are known to have given feedback on ways to avoid in-townment player breakdowns, of which

there have been many recently. Nitish Reddy, Washington Sundar, Harshith Rana and Varun Chakravarthy were unable to complete the series in which they were picked after experiencing muscle injuries.

Agarkar's future

There have also been concerns over instances of the selection committee's lack of communication with the team management and the COE. Those issues could not be addressed in Agarkar's absence. The chief selector was out of town and in a no-network zone. Agarkar's current tenure ends this month amid speculations over his continuation, even though he is eligible for a year's extension. The BCCI is expected to have discussions with Agarkar soon.

The BCCI refuted reports of VVS Laxman being considered for a higher role of Director of Cricket. "We haven't had any such discussions, nor do we have such an intention," said Saikia.

Record-breaking day for Smriti as India win it big

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NEW DELHI: Few things in cricket match the sight of Smriti Mandhana when she enters a flow state. Against Hong Kong, she found that rhythm and never quite let go, producing a sublime 124 off 64 balls to help India win by 137 runs in their Asia Cup fixture in Dubai on Thursday.

The Indian bowling line-up backed up Mandhana with a commanding display to bowl Hong Kong out for 56 runs, unsurprisingly led by Deepti Sharma (3/9) who also became the leading wicket-taker in T20Is with 174 wickets. Prema Rawat, Shree Chaurani and Nandini Sharma picked up two wickets apiece.

The opener from Sangli reached her highest individual score in T20Is, while also surpassing Mithali Raj to become the highest run-scorer in women's international cricket.

It's not as if Mandhana never has an off day. But she has shown time and again that she cannot remain quiet for too long, reinforcing her reputation as one of the most consistent and dependable performers not just for India, but in international women's cricket.

Her 10,880 international runs, and counting, have come by age 30, in a career spanning 13 years and precisely 302 matches. Going by the rate at which she is going, she has at least another five years to contribute to the game, making the magnitude of the achievement — and what may still lie ahead — even more exciting. Just last year, she broke the record for the most international runs by a woman in a calendar year, scoring 1,703 runs.

Mandhana's second century

Rewriting the record books

With 124 against Hong Kong, Mandhana brought up her second T20I ton and broke several records

Most runs in international cricket		
PLAYER	MATCHES	RUNS
Smriti Mandhana	302	10,880*
Mithali Raj	333	10,868
Suzie Bates	370	10,740
Charlotte Edwards	309	10,273
Sarah Taylor	307	10,007

Most centuries in international cricket		
SMRITI MANDHANA	MEG LANNING	LAURA WOLMER
18	17	17



in the format was also the highest individual score in the Women's T20 Asia Cup, surpassing Chamari Athapaththu's 119* against Malaysia in 2024.

It was a difficult outing for Hong Kong, who struggled to hit their length and every ball repressure on the Indian batsmen. Plagued by dropped catches and far too many loose deliveries, they were fortunate to get away early on when Mandhana and Shafali Verma got off to a relatively cautious start. India still reached 60/1 in the Powerplay.

After Shafali fell for 28, and with wickets continuing to tumble at the other end, Mandhana shifted gears to unleash total dominance and take India to 185/5. Such was the impact of her knock that the rest of the middle order's underwhelming show with the bat — the other Indian batters scored 62 from 56 deliveries — will be overshadowed yet again but will need a massive rethink from the

management. Funnily, it wasn't even Mandhana at her best. Her acceleration came late, but once she settled in, the lines and lengths of the bowlers ceased to matter. She found gaps almost at will, chased the ropes with ease and, as the innings wore on, made a difficult target look almost inevitable.

"I didn't know all of this happened. I was just trying to break several records en route to her century. It's really hard for me to play slower bowlers, but credit to them. They were really disciplined in the Powerplay. They bowled pretty well, and the kind of energy they showed was something which we all can learn from. Having said that, I just love batting, and I'm happy that I could contribute."

Brief scores: India 193/5 in 20 overs (5 Manjot Singh, M Lampugh 2/46) beat Hong Kong 56 all out in 16.2 overs (D Sharma 3/9) by 127 runs.

{ DULEEP TROPHY } FINAL

Rahul, Padikkal, Siraj asked to play, Vaibhav and Tilak is Gambhir's call

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NEW DELHI:

Debuting opener KL Rahul, Sri Lanka's hero Devdutt Padikkal and seasoned pacer Mohammed Siraj have been asked to play the Duleep Trophy final for South Zone against East Zone starting September 6 in Chennai.

It is understood that participation of South Zone skipper Tilak Varma, rising sensation Vaibhav Ishwarvanshi and keeper Ishan Kishan, all of whom are in India's T20I team, will depend on approval from India head coach Gautam Gambhir. "Rahul, Padikkal and Siraj do not have any competitive cricket right now. The national selectors want any

India player who is available should play the Duleep Trophy final. The trio played last on August 27. The next they will play is September 27 against West Indies in the ODIs. New Padikkal is not a part of ODIs so he might play India A series. But Duleep final if there is a chance, they should play. A BCCI source privy to the development told PTI on condition of anonymity.

In the case of Sooravanshi, Kishan and Tilak, it will be coach Gambhir's prerogative. The Duleep Trophy will assemble in Delhi on either September 9 or 10. If head coach wants all three to report for T20I team's third test, he will have to call them. But if head coach wants them to play the final and report to Delhi on September 10 late evening,

they can also do that," he added. Even as the mystery surrounding his impending extension remains after he was excused from the all-important BCCI review meeting due to family commitments, chairman of selectors Ajit Agarwal will be in Chennai to watch the Duleep Trophy final. As of now his contract gets over on October 4 and it will be interesting whether BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia discusses the matter of his extension with him. The BCCI is planning to send Mayank Yadav, Kartik Tyagi and left-armers Mohsin Khan to the Asian Games in Japan to help the Indian team's training session as net bowlers on specific request of head coach VVS Laxman.

Yashvir comes in for injured Neeraj

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NEW DELHI: The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) on Thursday named Yashvir Singh as Neeraj Chopra's replacement for the Asian Games (September 19-October 4) while long-distance runner Abhishek Pal and 100m hurdler Tejas Shirshe have been omitted from the squad. India's track and field squad now stands at 77.

Yashvir, a bronze medalist at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, expectedly made the cut after defending champion Chopra pulled out due to a torn ankle ligament. Yashvir will join Rohit Yadav as India's media hope in men's javelin. The 2023 edition of Asian Games saw a first-ever India 1-2 in javelin with Chopra and Kishore Jena taking the top two spots. "We have brought in Yashvir who is a CWG medal winner in place of Neeraj Chopra who is currently injured. It was an injury replacement, so there was no problem (in Yashvir coming in)," AFI President Bahadur Singh Sagoo said in Ludhiana.

Hurdler Shirshe, who made the initial list, sustained two stress fractures in his left foot during the Glasgow CWG, which brought a premature end to his season. "Long-distance runner Abhishek Pal has been dropped because of the issues he is facing. So this is the final team for the Asian Games," Sagoo added.



Yashvir Singh.

(NADA) last month after his sample was found to contain female fertility drug which officials said was "below threshold level". "It's not a case of (Abhishek) returning of the substance was below threshold level. NADA is currently investigating but we did not want to take any risk. So, we have dropped Abhishek from the team," AFI's planning commission chief Lalit Bhanot said.

Shirshe and Abhishek were included in the 73-member Indian athletics team announced by the sports ministry this month. The ministry added six more track and field athletes on Wednesday.

Meanwhile, the list of coaches and support staff released by the ministry features a first-ever Safeguarding Officer in the contingent following a mandate by the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA). Softball Association of India president Netai Narang has been given that charge. She will be the athletes' point of contact for matters related to harassment, abuse or neglect.

Back from the brink, Asiad-bound Rahi aims for the bullseye yet again

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NEW DELHI: When Rahi Sarnobat boards the flight to Japan this month for her third Asian Games, she will have marked a significant personal milestone. Having almost quit four years ago due to neuropathic pain syndrome, Rahi, over 18 excruciating months, found the wherewithal to push her mind and body enough to make it to the Indian team alongside young stars Manu Bhaker and Esha Singh. "It still feels like a dream," Rahi said.

"To suddenly lose your skills one day, struggle to get through your days, unlearn, relearn, and somehow be good enough to compete for India... it's a rebirth of sorts." A gold medalist in the 2018 edition, Rahi remains the only Indian to win an individual 25m pistol gold at the Asiad. The Indian shooting landscape, particularly in pistol disciplines, has undergone a sea change since then. The squad has become younger, the scores have gone higher, and the medal count elite competitions has become more consistent. "I still feel I am relevant. That said, shooting is not the centre of my life anymore," she said.

That's because, in the autumn of 2022, Rahi woke up one morning with her right leg immobile. "I knew that instant my shooting career was over," she remembered. A world No.1 just a year

On comeback trail

Pistol veteran **Rahi Sarnobat**, having recovered from neuropathic pain syndrome, will represent India in her pet 25m pistol event at the Asian Games. A quick look at her career:

AT ASIAN GAMES		
Bronze in Incheon, 2014 (team)	Gold in Palembang, 2018 (individual)	
AT WORLD CUPS (individual only)		
Gold in Changwon, 2013	Gold in Munich, 2019	Gold in Osaka, 2021
		Silver in New Delhi, 2021

before, Rahi spent the next 18 months recovering from neuropathic pain syndrome. A chronic condition affecting the nervous system, it left her dealing with debilitating pain across her body. "Everything from my eyelashes to my toe pained. Just getting through the day was a task. Pain became a constant companion. The mind began to play tricks

too...sometimes, on a perfectly sunny day, I would feel drenched. There were times when sitting on a sofa, I would feel my body sinking into quicksand. It was crazy." Rahi began taking baby steps into shooting in 2023 and only now is she completely off medication. Her return necessitated technical and equipment resets. She shed 20kg, tweaked her pis-

Rahi missed the cut for the Hangzhou Asian Games where Esha announced herself as one of India's leading 25m pistol shooters. Sporadic competitive appearances followed in 2024 without success and Rahi lost her place in the Indian team. "That was a huge blow. It was the first time in 15-17 years that I wasn't good enough to make the Indian team. But I had no option but to stay back and work hard."

Rahi's return to the practice range was equally humbling. For an athlete used to training 6-7 hours a day, firing a half-dozen shots became a tough task. "I just couldn't stand still. I needed tremendous mental strength. I had to create neuropathic pathways again. It was a slow process but I kept pushing, one step at a time. It was like starting from scratch," she recalled.

A gold in the 2025 National Games in Uttarakhand was a reminder that the skills hadn't totally deserted her. She made it back to the national squad and competed in Cairo World Championships in November and Munich editions of World Cup, Asian Championships in Shymkent — all in 2025.

The comeback took a decisive turn in 2026 when she won selection trials (T4) that pushed her to third in national rankings, behind Esha and Manu. "I had forgotten how to stand still. And here I am, still standing, still fighting."



VIRIN KUMAR/PT PHOTO

Srikanth stuns Lai in China Masters

SHENZHEN: Veteran Indian shuttler Kidambi Srikanth stunned world No.9 Victor Lai of Canada 2-18, 21-19 to enter the men's singles quarter-finals of China Masters here on Thursday. Men's doubles pair of Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy beat French duo of Fanny and Popyor 21-15, 22-24, 21-9 to progress to quarters.

Anahat upsets world No.11

LONDON: World No.20 Anahat Singh advanced to the quarter-finals of the London Squash Classic with a thrilling 2-1 win over 11th-ranked Nele Gilis on Thursday. Reigning world junior champion Anahat beat eighth seed Gilis 13-11, 4-11, 11-8 in 39 minutes in Round 2 of the \$144,000 PSA Gold event in what was their first meeting.

Bosnia captain Dzeko to retire

SARAJEVO: Edin Dzeko will play a 152nd and final match for Bosnia-Herzegovina next month before ending his 19-year international career, he announced on Instagram.

